

## Chapter 1

The Cosmic Consciousness described  
Is not quite the timeless Origin.  
The Name that one puts into words  
Fails to hold the Essence.  
Beyond the empty division of heaven and earth,  
The Nameless is-  
The living ground of being.  
The Nameless bears the Essence;  
The names reveal the functions  
Of all the numberless compressions of Being,  
Born of the vast and silent Mother.  
Release your attachment to appearances,  
And the Tao will be there.  
The manifest and the immanent

The Tao described in words is not the real Tao.

Words cannot describe it.

Nameless, it is the source of creation.

Named, it is the mother of all things.

To see Tao the observer must be motiveless.

Those with selfish motives

The Tao which can be expressed is not the unchanging Tao; the name which can be named is not the unchanging name.

The nameless is the beginning of the Heaven Earth; the mother of all things is the nameable.

Thus, while the eternal non-being

The Tao that can be expressed is not the eternal Tao; The name that can be defined is not the unchanging name.

Non-existence is called the antecedent of heaven and earth; Existence is the mother of all things.

From eternal non-existence, therefore, we serenely observe the

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| <p>To Guide with Names</p> <p>To guide what can be guided is not constant guiding.</p> <p>To name what can be named is not constant naming.</p> <p>'Not-exist' names the beginning (boundary) of the cosmos (Heaven and earth)</p> <p>'Exists' names the mother of the ten-thousand natural kinds .</p> <p>Thus, to treat 'not-exist' as constant</p> |
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see only  
the surface, not the  
innermost depths.  
These two kinds of  
observers look alike,  
but differ in the  
insight of their  
observations.  
They look alike  
because they are both  
human.  
Within humanity is  
the key to the door of  
creation.

leads toward the fathomless, the eternal being conduct to the boundary.

Although these two have been differently named they come from the same.

As the same they may be described as the abysmal. The abyss of the abysmal is the gate of all mystery.

mysterious beginning of the Universe; From eternal existence we clearly see the apparent distinctions.

These two are the same in source and become different when manifested.

This sameness is called profundity. Infinite profundity is the gate whence comes the beginning of all parts of the Universe.

is desiring to use it to view its mysteries.

To treat 'exists' as constant is desiring to use it to view its manifestations.

These two emerge together yet have different names.

'Together'--call that 'obscure.' 'Obscure' it and it is more obscure.

... the gateway of a crowd of mysteries.

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| <p>Ego is the mud thrown into Nature's water:</p> <p>It lusts for beauty and reviles ugliness.</p> <p>It projects a stain that was never there.</p> <p>It grasps after the Good,</p> <p>And thus affirms Evil.</p> <p>Yet in the eye of the universe,</p> <p>The formed and the formless</p> <p>Create and support each other.</p> <p>The light and the dark dance and mingle</p> <p>Like the breath of lovers.</p> <p>Erase the division: act but don't strive.</p> <p>Teach but do not peddle pedantry.</p> <p>The Sage guides without speaking,</p> <p>Works through us in innocence,</p> | <p>Whenever the most beautiful is perceived ugliness arises, the least beautiful.</p> <p>Whenever good is perceived</p> <p>evil exists, its natural opposite.</p> <p>Perception involves opposites:</p> <p>Reality and fantasy are opposing thoughts.</p> <p>Difficult and simple oppose in degree.</p> <p>Long and short oppose in distance.</p> <p>High and low oppose in height.</p> <p>Shrill and deep oppose in tone.</p> | <p>When everyone in the world became conscious of the beauty of the beautiful it turned to evil; They became conscious of the goodness of the good and ceased to be good.</p> <p>Thus not-being and being arise the one from the other.</p> | <p>When all in the world understand beauty to be beautiful, then ugliness exists.</p> <p>When all understand goodness to be good, then evil exists.</p> <p>Thus existence suggests non-existence; Easy gives rise to difficult; Short</p>                | <p>Contrast of Terms</p> <p>That the social world knows to deem the beautiful as 'beautiful' simply creates the 'ugly. '</p> <p>That the social world knows to deem worth as 'worthy' simply creates 'worthlessness. '</p> <p>Thus 'exists' and 'not-exists' mutually sprout. 'Difficult' and 'easy' are mutually done.</p> <p>'Long' and 'short' are mutually gauged. 'High' and 'low' mutually incline.</p> <p>'Sound' and 'tone' mutually blend.</p> |
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If you create the great, and  
elevate it,  
You will lose your self.  
Become attached to your  
belongings  
And you open the inner door  
to thieves.  
Let the Sage guide you:  
Clear out your inner space,  
And your own truth will  
arise.  
Wear down attachment and  
division  
And you strengthen your  
will.  
Be led to shed the crust of  
knowledge;  
Cut through the cycle of want  
And reject all that you have  
been told to know.  
Follow the way of inner  
action:  
In the course of  
disburdenment,

Leaders Work Humbly

Leaders should not seek power or status; people will not then crave power or status.

If scarce goods are not valued highly, people will have no need to steal them.

If there is nothing available to arouse passion, people will remain content and

When worth is not honoured the people may be kept from strife.

When rare articles are not valued the people are kept from theft.

When the desirable is left unnoticed the heart is not confused.

Therefore, the method of government by the Holy Man is to empty the heart, while strengthening the purpose; to make the will pliant, and the character strong.

Not exalting the worthy keeps the people from emulation.

Not valuing rare things keeps them from theft.

Not showing what is desirable keeps their hearts from confusion.

Therefore the Sage rules By emptying their hearts, Filling their stomachs, Weakening

Prescriptions for Politics

Don't glorify the high-brow: cause people not to wrangle.

Don't value limited commodities: cause people not to contemplate stealing.

Don't display the desirable: prevent confusing the people's hearts-'n-minds.

Using these: The governance of sages: empties their hearts-'n-minds, stuffs

[illegible]

satisfied.

The truly wise do lead  
by instilling humility and  
open-mindedness,  
by providing for fair  
livelihoods,  
by discouraging  
personal ambition,  
by strengthening the  
bone-structure of the  
people.

The wise avoid evil  
and radical reform;  
thus the foolish do  
not obstruct them.

They work serenely,  
with inner quiet.

He ever keeps the people simple-minded and passionless, so that the world-wise do not dare to plan.

Practice non-action and everything will be regulated.

their ambitions And strengthening their bones.

He always keeps them from knowing what is evil and desiring what is good; thus he gives the crafty ones no chance to act.

He governs by non-action; consequently there is nothing un-governed.

their guts

Weaken their  
resolve, and  
strengthens their  
bones.

He treats causing the  
people to lack both  
knowledge and desire  
as constants.

Causing those with  
knowledge not to  
venture  
deeming-actions.

They deem the  
absence of  
deeming-action and  
thus nothing is  
ungoverned.

Empty, like a well, is the Cosmic Whole:

Empty, and forever inexhaustible.

Endless as the limitless

Forms of creation, drawn through Time-

Before its birth, beyond its reach-

Softening the jagged edges, Untangling complexity,

Dimming the garishness of excess

With the soil of its simplicity.

So dark, so empty—who could have made it?

It is the child of nothing,

The parent of us all.

Tao is a vast immeasurable void.

It can be used to infinity.

It is truly inexhaustible.

Like nature, it appears to be the origin of everything.

In it, conflicts (sharp edges) are satisfied (rounded).

Differences (tangles)

The Tao is as emptiness, so are its operations. It resembles non-fullness.

Fathomless! It seems to be the ancestor of all form.

It removes sharpness, unravels confusion,

Tao, when put in use for its hollowness, is not likely to be filled.

In its profundity it seems to be the origin of all

Using Guidance

Guidance pours out but in using it, something is not filled.

Whew! It's like the ancestor of the ten-thousand natural kinds.

'Dull' its 'sharp', 'untie' its

Water, even when it appears still to our eyes, is always in motion—wearing down the sharp and jagged, dissolving what is obdurate, softening glare—moving freely through its permutations between earth and sky, light and dark. Following the guideline that he established in Chapter 1, Lao Tzu describes the Cosmic Whole through what it does. But as for what it is, only stepping beyond the limits of reason can point the way: it is the emptiness that contains everything. It flows and it freezes; it evaporates and condenses; it merges into every element and state of being. It is the quantum darkness from which light freely flows—try to move it, and it is still; try to stop it, and it will always be moving.

are resolved (untied).

Observations (light) are clarified (tempered).

Disturbances (turmoil) are quieted (submerged).

It is like a deep dark pool.

I do not know its source.

It is like a prelude to nature,

a preface to God.

harmonizes brightness, and becomes one with everything.

Pellucid! It bears the appearance of permanence.

I know not whose son it is. Its Noumenon was before the Lord.

things.

In its depth it seems ever to remain.

I do not know whose offspring it is; But it looks like the predecessor of Nature.

'tie', 'blend' its 'bright', 'together' its 'diffused particles'.

Ooo! It's like it partly endures.

I don't know whose son it is.

It is before the emperor of signs!

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| <p>Equality is the Cosmic Way:</p> <p>Good and evil are born of fantasy.</p> <p>The Sage is neither partisan nor punishing:</p> <p>No one is special, no one excluded.</p> | <p>Nature is indifferent to life.</p> <p>It realizes everything is as a straw dog</p> <p>(a sacrificial animal-image).</p> <p>The truly wise are also indifferent to life.</p> <p>They realize humanity</p> | <p>Nature is non-benevolent. It regards the masses as straw dogs.</p> <p>The Holy Man is non-benevolent. He regards the masses as straw dogs.</p> <p>The space between the heaven and the earth is like a</p> | <p>Heaven and earth do not own their benevolence, To them all things are straw dogs</p> <p>The Sage does not own his benevolence; To him the people are straw dogs.</p> <p>The space between heaven and earth is like a (blacksmith's) bellows.</p> | <p>Natural Guidance</p> <p>Heaven-earth [the cosmos] is not kind. It treats the 10,000 natural kinds as straw dogs.</p> <p>Sages are not kind. They treat the hundred surname-groups as straw dogs.</p> <p>Is the space between</p> |
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| <p>Consciousness breathes,</p> <p>Expands and contracts.</p> <p>It never varies, and each moment is unique.</p> <p>Work with this and understand;</p> <p>Talk about it, and you lose your center.</p> | <p>is as a straw dog.</p> <p>The universe is like a bellows:</p> <p>empty, yet quite full.</p> <p>As it proceeds, it produces.</p> <p>Much talk, much exhaustion.</p> <p>Keep your thoughts within!</p> | <p>bellows; though unsupported, it does not warp; when in motion the more it expels.</p> <p>Though words could exhaust this theme, they would not be so profitable as the preservation of its inner essence.</p> | <p>Hollow as it seems, nothing is lacking. If it is moved, more will it bring forth.</p> <p>He who talks more is sooner exhausted: It is better to keep what is within himself.</p> | <p>Heaven and earth not like bellows and flutes?</p> <p>Empty and not warped.</p> <p>As long as you move them, they produce.</p> <p>Many words and numbers unlimited are not as good as holding the center.</p> |
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| <p>The valley is ever open and alive;</p> <p>It is the mother of consciousness.</p> <p>In night-flower darkness</p> <p>The bounty of Nature is</p> | <p>The concept of Yin is ever present.</p> <p>It is the Mystic Female from</p> | <p>The Valley-God never dies. She may be styled the Mother of the Abyss.</p> | <p>'The Valley and the Spirit never die.'<br/>They form what is called the Mystic Mother,.</p> <p>From whose gate comes the origin of heaven and earth.</p> <p>'The Valley and the Spirit never die.'<br/>They form what is called the Mystic Mother, From whose gate comes the origin of heaven and earth.</p> | <p>The Superiority of the Female</p> <p>The Valley energy never dies.</p> <p>This is called 'fathomless female'</p> <p>The channel of the</p> |
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| <p>concealed</p> <p>Until, looking within, we see</p> <p>The mystery extinguished, the curtain drawn</p> <p>From the heart of the Mother of the Cosmos.</p> | <p>whom</p> <p>the heavens and the earth originate.</p> <p>Constantly, continuously, enduring always.</p> <p>Use her!</p> | <p>The Abysmal Mother's orifice may be called the Root of the Heaven-Earth.</p> <p>Continuous she is as though ever abiding, and may be employed without weariness.</p> | <p>This (the origin) seems ever to endure. In use it can never be exhausted.</p> | <p>fathomless female:</p> <p>This is called the basis of the cosmos.</p> <p>Silken! It's as if it abides.</p> <p>Handle it gently!</p> |
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| <p>Consciousness is eternal-but why?</p> <p>Because time does not adhere to its nature.</p> <p>Time and desire, abstraction and attachment</p> <p>Cannot touch it.</p> <p>It transforms, completes, and teaches</p> <p>All of its aspects,</p> <p>Within life and beyond death.</p> | <p>The heavens endure; the earth is very old. Why?</p> <p>Because they do not exist for themselves, they therefore have long life.</p> <p>The truly wise are content to</p>                                            | <p>Nature continues long. What is the reason that Nature continues long?</p> <p>Because it produces nothing for itself it is able to constantly produce.</p> <p>It is for this reason that the Holy Man puts himself in the background; yet he comes to the front.</p> | <p>Heaven is lasting and earth enduring.</p> <p>The reason why they are lasting and enduring is that they do not live for themselves; Therefore they live long.</p> <p>In the same way</p>            | <p>Intentional Reversal</p> <p>Heaven is old and Earth is enduring.</p> <p>What do Heaven and Earth rely on in order to be old and enduring?</p> <p>They rely on avoiding self creation.</p> <p>Hence they can be old and</p>                             |
| <p>The Sage remains behind</p> <p>And thus it stays ahead.</p> <p>The student drops his ego</p> <p>And thus his true self arises.</p> <p>Separation and division of being are overcome,</p> <p>Each need is fulfilled</p> <p>As each excess is abandoned.</p>                       | <p>be last;</p> <p>they are therefore first.</p> <p>They are indifferent to themselves; they are therefore self-confident.</p> <p>Perhaps because they do not exist for themselves they find complete fulfillment.</p> | <p>He is indifferent to himself; yet he is preserved.</p> <p>Is it not because he has no interests of his own that he is able to secure his interests?</p>                                                                                                             | <p>the Sage keeps himself behind and he is in the front;</p> <p>He forgets himself and he is preserved.</p> <p>Is it not because he is not self-interested That his self-interest is established?</p> | <p>enduring.</p> <p>Using this: Sages 'later' themselves and yet they comes first.</p> <p>They 'outside' themselves and yet they abide.</p> <p>Is this not a case of their lacking selfishness?</p> <p>So they are able to achieve their selfishness.</p> |

Like water is the Cosmic Consciousness:

It nourishes the depths of everything that lives.

It flows, it settles, it abides in low places.

Keep your home close to the earth,

Keep your thoughts direct and simple,

Keep judgment fair, and fluid in conflict,

Keep your government free of power,

And your personal affairs in harmony

With the life of Nature.

Drop the struggle, silence the demons,

And your natural self will be free.

Following Tao is not about adopting an attitude of passivity, but nurturing inner strength instead. —

The highest motive is to be like water.

Water is essential to all life,

yet it does not demand a fee

or proclaim its importance.

Rather, it flows humbly to the lowest level,

and in so doing it is much like Tao.

In the home the truly wise love the humble

The highest goodness resembles water.

Water greatly benefits all things, but does not assert itself.

He approximates to the Tao, who abides by that which men despise.

He revolutionizes the place in which he dwells; his depth is immeasurable; he strengthens

The highest goodness is like water. Water is beneficent to all things but does not contend. It stays in places which others despise. Therefore it is near Tao.

In dwelling, think it a good place to live; In feeling, make the

The Worth of Water

Higher worth is like water.

Water is good at benefiting the ten-thousand natural kinds

Without wrangling for position.

What the crowd despises

Hence close to the guide.

In dwelling value the

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earth,

the foundation on which the home is built.

In the heart they love what is genuine.

In friendship they are compassionate.

In words they are sincere.

In government they foster peace and goodwill.

In business they work with quiet efficiency.

Serenity is the goal of Tao.

Through it nothing is lost.

moral qualities by what he bestows; he augments sincerity by what he says; he evokes peace by his administration; his transactions manifest ability, he is opportune in all his movements.

Forasmuch as he does not assert himself he is free from blame.

heart deep; In friendship, keep on good terms with men; In words, have confidence;

In ruling, abide by good order; In business, take things easy; In motion, make use of the opportunity.

Since there is no contention, there is no blame.

earth.

In heart-mind value depth.

In being-with value kindness.

In words value reliability.

In rectifying value order.

In social affairs value ability.

In action value timing.

In general, simply don't wrangle

Hence have no indiscretion.



## Chapter 9

Overstuff your life with thought,  
And it will stiffen and suffer.  
Keep an eye out for trouble,  
And you invite it in.  
Make wealth your sole objective  
And your heart will grow rigid as ice.  
Let fame define you  
And you become a stranger to yourself.  
Stop the treadmill and renounce expectation:  
This is entering the Cosmic rhythm.  
We have a phrase in vernacular English for what Lao Tzu is describing here: it is called "paralysis by analysis." Nothing so stiffens feeling, foreshortens influence, or limits understanding, as intellectual reductionism. —

There is a danger in extremes:  
Pull a bowstring too far,  
and you wish you had let go before.  
Hone a sword-edge too sharp,  
and the edge will wear too soon.  
Fill your house with gold

It is better to leave alone, than to grasp at fullness.

Sharpness, which results from filing, cannot be preserved.

None can protect the hall that

Holding and keeping  
a thing to the very  
full - it is better to  
leave it alone;

Handling and  
sharpening a blade -  
it cannot be long  
sustained;

When gold and jade  
fill

The inconstancy of achievement

To grasp and pile things up is not as good as regarding it as already done.

When you measure and build a pillar , you cannot preserve

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and jade,  
and you invite  
thieves.

Be proud and  
arrogant over good  
fortune,  
and you prepare your  
own downfall.

When you have  
reached your goal,  
be satisfied to go no  
further.

This is the way of  
Tao.

is filled with gold  
and jade.

Opulence, honours,  
pride, necessarily  
bequeath calamity.

Merit established, a  
name made, then  
retirement – this is  
the way of Heaven.

the hall, no one can  
protect them;  
Wealth and honour  
with pride bring with  
them destruction;  
To have  
accomplished merit  
and acquired fame,  
then to retire - This is  
the Tao of heaven.

it for long.

When gold and jade  
fill the hall, you can't  
keep any of it.

Rich, ennobled and  
thus proud bequeaths  
ruin.

With success,  
disappear: this is the  
heavenly guide.

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| <p>Nourish every sense,<br/>Embrace your undivided nature.<br/>Let your chi course fresh and fluid<br/>With the iridescence of a newborn body.<br/>Cleanse guilt and shame-the mud of culture-<br/>From all your being,<br/>And feel your natural form.<br/>Let yourself be led by the fearless love<br/>Of a caring Cosmos.<br/>Close the gates of Heaven,<br/>Abandon manipulation,<br/>Open yourself to the perfect</p> | <p>Can you control your mind<br/>so that it never strays from the way of Tao?<br/>Can you control your breathing<br/>so that it is soft and gentle<br/>like a new-born babe?<br/>Can you purify yourself<br/>so that you are perfect?<br/>Can you</p> | <p>By steadily disciplining the animal nature, until it becomes one pointed, it is possible to establish the Indivisible.<br/>By undivided attention to the soul, rendering it passive, it is possible to become as an infant child.<br/>By purifying the mind of phantasms, it is possible to become without fault.<br/>By perfecting the people, and pacifying</p> | <p>Can you keep the soul always concentrated from straying?<br/>Can you regulate the breath and become soft and pliant like an infant?<br/>Can you clear and get rid of the unforeseen and be free</p> | <p>Impossible Advice<br/>In general:<br/>In mustering your vitalities, embracing in one, can you fail to distinguish?<br/>In specializing in breath and consummating weakness, can you be a child?<br/>In cleansing and voiding your profound mirror, can you be without flaw?<br/>In loving the people and ordering the state, can you fail to</p> |
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| <p>nature<br/>That has always been there.<br/>Release the Sage within you<br/>And let your clarity extend<br/>To every corner of the universe.<br/>Then may your words and actions<br/>Nourish, develop, and sustain<br/>Others as well as yourself.<br/>When you realize that there is nothing to claim,<br/>Nothing to assert,<br/>Nothing to control,<br/>Nothing to dominate;</p> | <p>love all the people, rule them, and remain unknown?<br/>And do so without interference?<br/>Can you play the same role always?<br/>Give birth, provide nourishment;<br/>do this without being possessive.<br/>Give help without obligation.<br/>Lead without dominating.<br/>This is the Mytic Virtue (Teh).</p> | <p>the empire, it is possible to prove non-attachment.<br/>By functioning on the super-physical planes, it is possible to be independent of the lower mind.<br/>By making intuition omniscient, it is impossible to discard knowledge.<br/>Producing!<br/>Nourishing!<br/>Developing, without self-consciousness!<br/>Acting, without seeking the fruit!<br/>Progressing, without thinking of growth!<br/>This is the abyss of energy.</p> | <p>from fault?<br/>Can you love the people and govern the state by non-action?<br/>Can you open and shut the gates of nature like a female?<br/>Can you become enlightened and penetrate everywhere without knowledge?</p> | <p>know?<br/>In opening and closing the heavenly channel, can you fail to be female?<br/>In discerning all within the four directions, can you fail to deem-act?<br/>Generate it, nourish it:<br/>Generate it and not 'exist' it.<br/>Deem: act and not rely on anything.<br/>Become 'elder' and not rule.<br/>These are called 'profound virtuosities.'</p> |
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Thirty spokes unite around a  
single hub:  
Thus a wheel is made.  
Yet it is the formless core  
That makes the wagon roll.  
Clay is formed and baked:  
Thus a cup is made.  
Yet it is the invisible interior  
From which we drink.  
Framed walls and brick are  
joined  
To make a house.  
Yet it is the open space  
within  
That makes it livable,  
That gives doors and  
windows  
Their unique functions.  
Therefore, make being your  
element,  
But non-being, your life.

Thirty spokes unite at  
the hub of a wheel  
but the ultimate use  
of the wheel  
depends on the part  
where nothing exists.  
Clay is molded into a  
vessel  
but the ultimate use  
of the vessel  
depends on the part  
where nothing exists.  
Doors and

Thirty spokes meet in one hub, but the need for the cart existed when as yet it was not. Clay is fashioned into vessels, but the need for the vessel existed when as yet it was not.

Thirty spokes unite in one nave, And because of the part where nothing exists we have the use of a carriage wheel.

Clay is moulded into vessels, And because of the space where nothing exists we are able to use them as vessels.

The Value of  
Non-existence

Thirty spokes  
together make one  
hub.

Where the nothing is,  
lies the cart's use.

Throwing clay to  
deem: make a  
utensil;

Where the nothing is,  
lies the utensil's use.

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windows are cut  
from the walls of a  
house  
but the ultimate use  
of the house  
depends on the part  
where nothing exists.  
So there is advantage  
in using  
what can be seen,  
what does exist.  
There is also  
advantage in using  
the invisible, the  
non-existent.

Doors and windows are cut out to make a house, but the need for the house existed when as yet it was not. Hence there is a profitableness in that which is and a need in that which is not.

Doors and windows are cut out in the walls of a house, And because they are empty spaces, we are able to use them.

Therefore, on the one hand we have the benefit of existence, and on the other, we make use of non-existence.

Sculpting windows  
and doors to deem:  
make a room;  
Where the nothing is,  
lies the room's use.  
So where we deem  
having it as  
beneficial.  
We deem use to  
consist in lacking it.

Rampant color impairs vision;  
A profusion of sound obstructs the ear;  
Gluttonous tastes poison the mouth;  
Attachment to belief warps the self;  
Predatory impulse reviles the treasure.  
The Sage uses the outer to point to the inner;  
By exposing the image, it shows us ourselves.  
Self-display corrupts your ability to see within; making noise about yourself closes off your inner ear; the Tao itself cannot be tasted when one is obsessed with outer sensation. —

Five colors (blue, yellow, red, white, black)  
blind the eye.  
Five notes (do, re, mi, so, la)  
deafen the ear.  
Five tastes (sweet, sour, bitter, pungent, salt)  
dull the tongue.  
Hunting

The five colours blind men's eyes.  
The five tones deafen one's ears.  
The five flavours blunt men's appetites.  
Gallop and hunting derange men's minds.  
Articles which are rare limit the

The five colours will blind a man's sight.  
The five sounds will deaden a man's hearing. The five tastes will spoil a man's palate.  
Chasing and hunting will drive a man wild

The Numbing Effect of the Conventional  
The five colors stupefy the people's eyes.  
The five tones desensitize the people's ears.  
The five flavors numb the people's mouths.  
Horse races and

Lao Tzu never asks us to abandon the delights available to our outer senses; he simply asks us to place them in a more holistic context, one that allows equality to our inner senses.

and pursuing will unbalance the mind.  
Striving for earthly goods produces unhealthy tension.  
Therefore the truly wise  
satisfy the internal and reject the external.  
They accept one and deny the other.

freedom of men's actions.  
On this account the holy man regards the stomach and not the eye.  
He puts aside the one, that he may take the other in hand.

Things hard to get will do harm to a man's conduct.  
Therefore the Sage makes provision for the stomach and not for the eye. He rejects the latter and chooses the former.

hunting derange the people's heart-minds.  
Hard to get goods pervert the people's behavior.  
Using this: Sages deem: act for the gut not the eye.  
So they choose this and reject that.

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| <p>Great renown is more deadly than disgrace;</p> <p>To impugn your bodily nature is self-loathing.</p> <p>Fear is the blood of fame;</p> <p>Your own imbalance is the fuel</p> <p>Of favor-seeking and the lust for praise.</p> <p>The only real misfortune</p> <p>Is to look at Nature and see affliction.</p> <p>When the treasure is split from its source,</p> <p>Body and nature become a well of sorrow.</p> <p>Cherish your bodily being;</p> <p>Reconnect with the Source.</p> <p>Creating and dissolving are one in the Cosmos:</p> <p>Honor the life of the body, and your care will extend</p> <p>To the formless Essence.</p> | <p>It is said:</p> <p>Both good fortune and misfortune cause tension.</p> <p>The creative and the destructive</p> <p>exist equally in the mind.</p> <p>How can both good fortune and misfortune cause tension?</p> <p>Those with good fortune are tense anticipating their gift;</p> <p>those with misfortune are tense lamenting their loss.</p> <p>How can the creative and destructive</p> | <p>Equally fear favour and disgrace.</p> <p>Regard a great calamity as you do your own body.</p> <p>What is meant by "Equally fear favour and grace?" Favour should be disparaged. Gained or lost it arouses apprehension. Hence it is said, "Equally fear favour and disgrace."</p> <p>What is meant by "regard a great calamity as you do your own body?" Why have I any sense of misfortune?</p> | <p>'Favour and disgrace are like fear; fortune and disaster are like our body.'</p> <p>What does it mean by 'Favour and disgrace are like fear'? Favour is in a higher place, and disgrace in a lower place. When you win them you are like being in fear, and when you lose them you are also like being in fear. So favour and disgrace are like fear.</p> <p>What does it mean by 'Fortune and disaster are like our body'?</p> | <p>Status</p> <p>Favor is as disgraceful as a warning.</p> <p>Nobility is as great a trouble as a self.</p> <p>Why say 'favor is as disgraceful as a warning'?</p> <p>The favored is deemed below.</p> <p>Receiving it is like a warning.</p> <p>Losing it is like a warning.</p> <p>This is called 'favor is as disgraceful as a warning.'</p> <p>Why say 'nobility is as great a trouble as a self'?</p> <p>Deeming</p> |
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| <p>Look for it-it is invisible;</p> <p>Listen for it-it is silent;</p> <p>Try to grasp it-it is not solid.</p> <p>Its nature is bodiless,</p> <p>Yet it is the essence of body.</p> <p>Its darkness is the source of light,</p> <p>Its infinitude, the ground of time.</p> <p>It is the Formless One</p> <p>From</p> | <p>Looked for it cannot be seen; it is invisible.</p> <p>Listened for it cannot be heard; it is inaudible.</p> <p>Reached for it cannot be touched; it is intangible.</p> <p>These three are beyond analysis; these three are one.</p> <p>It rises like the sun, but does not illuminate.</p> <p>It sets like the sun, but does not darken.</p> <p>Without beginning, without end, it</p> | <p>Looked for but invisible – it may be named "colourless."</p> <p>Listened for, but inaudible – it may be named "elusive."</p> <p>Clutched at, but unattainable - is may be named "subtle."</p> <p>These three cannot be unraveled by questioning for they blend into one.</p> <p>Neither brighter above , nor darker below.</p> <p>Its line, though continuous, is nameless, and in that it reverts to vacuity.</p> | <p>That which we look at and cannot see is called plainness. That which we listen to and cannot hear is called rareness. That which we grope for and cannot get is called minuteness.</p> <p>These three cannot be closely examined; So they blend into One.</p> <p>Revealed, it is not dazzling; Hidden, it is not dark. Infinite, it cannot be defined. It goes back to non-existence.</p> | <p>Metaphysical Issues</p> <p>Look at it and fail to see: its name is 'remote.'</p> <p>Listen to it and fail to hear: its name is 'diffuse.'</p> <p>Feel it and fail to get anything: its name is 'subtle.'</p> <p>This threesome cannot be exhaustively probed for portents.</p> <p>Hence we blend them and deem them as one.</p> <p>Its height is not sparkling.</p> <p>Its depth is not murky.</p> <p>String-like, it cannot be named.</p> <p>It</p> |
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| <p>which all forms arise.</p> <p>Pursue, and it eludes you;</p> <p>Follow, and it vanishes.</p> <p>Thought cannot hold it,</p> <p>But you can't think without it.</p> <p>It is the thread of all being,</p> <p>The origin, the pulse of time.</p> <p>It is the wave upon the strand of life:</p> <p>Pervading, defining, nourishing.</p> | <p>is infinite, undefinable.</p> <p>It is the form of the formless;</p> <p>it is existence in non-existence;</p> <p>it is the greatest mystery.</p> <p>Meet it and it has no face;</p> <p>follow it and it has no back.</p> <p>Hold close to the ancient Tao</p> <p>and be master of your present existence.</p> <p>Knowing the present you mirror the past.</p> <p>This is the clue to Tao.</p> | <p>formless"; "The Images of the imageless"; in a word – "The indefinite."</p> <p>Go in front of it and you will discover no beginning; follow after it and you will perceive no ending.</p> <p>Lay hold of this ancient doctrine; apply it in controlling the things of the present day, you will then</p> <p>understand how from the first it has been the origin of everything.</p> <p>Here, indeed, is the clue to the Tao.</p> | <p>It is called the form of the formless, And the image of non~existence. it is called mystery. Meet it, you cannot see its face; Follow it, you cannot see its back.</p> <p>By adhering to the Tao of the past You will master the existence of the present And be able to know the origin of the past. This is called the clue of Tao.</p> | <p>reverts to being no natural kind.</p> <p>This we call the condition of being in no condition; the sign of no natural kind.</p> <p>This we call 'confused' and 'indistinct.'</p> <p>Facing it you cannot see its head; Following it you cannot see its rear</p> <p>If you grasp guiding discourse from ancient times in dealing with today's reality</p> <p>you can know the ancient beginnings.</p> <p>This is called a guiding discourse's record.</p> |
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| <p>The one who wrote these bone-old words</p> <p>Set out to draw the veil of Mystery</p> <p>From the truth of his moment.</p> <p>It was impenetrable to logic,</p> <p>But the subtle dance of verse</p> <p>Could pierce the appearance,</p> <p>And neutralize the profundity.</p> <p>He was cautiously humble,</p> <p>As if walking on ice.</p> <p>Ever conscious of danger,</p> <p>He approached his undertaking</p> <p>With watchful reserve,</p> <p>Like a visitor to far-off shores:</p> <p>Pliant, like ice in the spring,</p> <p>Malleable, like fresh yew,</p> <p>Open, like a mountain valley.</p> | <p>The Tao of the Ancients</p> <p>The ancient followers of the Tao:</p> <p>so wise, so subtle, so profound,</p> <p>so deeply understanding,</p> <p>that they were themselves misunderstood.</p> <p>They must therefore be described.</p> <p>Cautious, like crossing a stream in mid-winter;</p> <p>observant, like moving in fear through hostile land;</p> <p>modest, retiring like ice beginning to melt;</p> <p>dignified, like an honored guest;</p> <p>genuine, like natural, untouched wood;</p> | <p>Profound indeed were the most excellent among the ancients, penetrating, fathomless; inasmuch as they were fathomless it becomes necessary to employ far fetched symbols when speaking of them.</p> <p>Irresolute – as if fording a stream in winter.</p> <p>Timid – as though fearful of their neighbours.</p> <p>Grave – as if they were guests.</p> <p>Elusive – like ice about to melt.</p> <p>Simple –</p> | <p>In old times the perfect man of Tao was subtle, penetrating and so profound that he can hardly be understood.</p> <p>Because he cannot be understood, I shall endeavour to picture him: He is cautious, like one who crosses a stream in winter; He is hesitating, like one who fears his neighbours; He is modest, like one who is a guest;</p> <p>He is yielding, like ice that is going to melt; He is simple, like wood that</p>            | <p>Mastering Guiding Discourse</p> <p>Those in ancient times who were good at deem: acting as scholars</p> <p>Were subtlety mysterious and profoundly receptive</p> <p>Unfathomably deep.</p> <p>Now, precisely because unfathomable,</p> <p>We must force a description of them.</p> <p>Cautious: like crossing a stream in winter.</p> <p>Ambivalent: like fearing those on all sides.</p> <p>Exacting: like being a guest</p> <p>Mutable: like ice on</p> |
| <p>—</p> <p>—</p> <p>—</p> <p>—</p> <p>—</p> <p>—</p> <p>—</p> <p>—</p> <p>—</p> <p>—</p> <p>—</p> <p>—</p> <p>—</p> <p>—</p> <p>—</p> <p>—</p> <p>—</p> <p>—</p> <p>—</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 | <p>open valley;</p> <p>friendly, like muddied water, freely mixing.</p> <p>Who can make sense of a world like cloudy water?</p> <p>Left alone and still, it becomes clear.</p> <p>Should this stillness be maintained?</p> <p>Moving hastily will surely cloud it again.</p> <p>How then can one move and not become clouded?</p> <p>Accept Tao and achieve without being selfish;</p> <p>being unselfish one endures the world's wear,</p> <p>and needs no change of pace.</p>                        | <p>like raw material.</p> <p>Expansive – like the space between hills.</p> <p>Turbid – like muddy water.</p> <p>Who can still the turbid and make it gradually clear; or quiet the active so that by degrees it shall become productive? Only he who keeps this Tao, without desiring fullness. If one is not full it is possible to be antiquated and not newly fashioned.</p>                                    | <p>is not yet wrought; He is vacant, like valleys that are hollow; He is dim, like water that is turbid.</p> <p>Who is able to purify the dark till it becomes slowly light? Who is able to calm the turbid till it slowly clears? Who is able to quicken the stagnant till it slowly makes progress?</p> <p>He who follows these principles does not desire fullness. Because he is not full, therefore when he becomes decayed he can renew.</p> | <p>the point of melting</p> <p>Unaffected: like uncarved wood.</p> <p>Munificent: like a valley</p> <p>Obscure: like muddied water</p> <p>Who can, while muddy, using calmness gradually become clear?</p> <p>Who can, while at ease, using activity gradually come to life.?</p> <p>She who embraces this guiding discourse doesn't desire fulfilling.</p> <p>Now precisely because not fulfilled,</p> <p>she can obscure and not newly fabricate.</p>      |

While sitting in stillness,  
Connect with the Cosmic  
Harmony.

By clearing the space within,  
In steadfast quietude,  
Let your true self observe  
The numberless  
compressions of  
consciousness:

How they arise and recede,  
Coming into being and  
blooming;

Retreating at last toward the  
Cosmic Origin.

Return to the root, to the  
primal nature,  
Is the way of all beings.

Let your awareness  
contemplate  
The eternal cycle of return,  
And your insight will deepen  
in this.

The understanding that is  
nurtured

Achieve the highest goal  
by being passive;  
hold close to a state of  
perfect serenity.  
Everything comes into  
existence,  
but observe, returns to its  
source.  
Thus, vegetation  
flourishes and grows,  
but returns to the soil  
whence it came.  
Returning to the source is  
serenity;  
it is to realize one's  
destiny.  
To realize one's destiny  
is to know the Eternal  
Constant.  
To know the Eternal  
Constant  
is to be enlightened.  
To be ignorant

Abstraction complete, quiescence maintained unalloyed, the various forms rise with one accord, and I observe that each returns again. All things thrive and increase, then each returns again to the root. This return to the root is called "stillness," or it may be described as a return to report that they have fulfilled their destiny.

This report is called "the unchanging —  
rul —  
e —  
. —  
"

Attain to the goal of absolute vacuity;  
Keep to the state of perfect peace.

All things come into existence, And  
thence we see them return. Look at the  
things that have been flourishing; Each  
goes back to its origin.

Going back to the origin is called  
peace; It means reversion to destiny.  
Reversion to destiny is called eternity.

Being a Guide

Go to the limit of  
emptiness

Take on quiet  
dependability

The ten-thousand  
natural kinds are all  
dealt with.

And I thus view their  
response

In general, natural  
kinds flourish.

Each responds by  
returning to its root.

Returning to the root  
is called quietude.

This I call  
responding to the  
word.

Responding

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of this  
is blindness that begets  
evil.

Whoever knows the  
Eternal Constant  
is open-minded. Being  
open-minded  
is to be impartial. Being  
impartial  
is to be above nations and  
laws.

Being above nations and  
laws  
is to be in accord with  
nature.

Being in accord with  
nature  
is to be in accord with  
Tao.

Being in accord with Tao  
is to be eternal.

Although his body may  
die and decay,

Knowledge of this unchanging rule is called "illumination." Those who are ignorant of it give way to abandon and to recklessness.

Knowledge of this unchanging rule leads to toleration.

Toleration leads to comprehension.

Comprehension leads to sovereignty.

Sovereignty leads to heavenlikeness.

Heaven-likeness leads to Tao.

Tao leads to continuity.

He who knows eternity is called enlightened. He who does not know eternity is running blindly into miseries. Knowing eternity he is all-embracing. Being all-embracing he can attain magnanimity. Being magnanimous he can attain omnipresence. Being omnipresent he can attain supremacy. Being supreme he can attain Tao.

He who attains Tao is everlasting. Though his body may decay he never perishes.

to the word we describe as 'constant'.  
To know what is constant we describe as 'discernment'.  
Not to know what is constant is wantonly taking risks.  
To know what is constant is openness;  
Open thus equitable;  
Equitable thus kindly;  
Kindly thus natural;  
Natural thus guiding;  
Guiding thus enduring  
Doesn't stop when you bury the body.



|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |                                                                                                                                                                                                 |                                                                                                                                                                                        |                                                                                                                                                                             |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
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| <p>The truly developed self<br/>Is ever aware of the Cosmic Presence.<br/>Another may abide<br/>In love and praise of it;<br/>Still another might fear it;<br/>And finally there are those<br/>Who hold it in contempt.<br/>Trust is not built on</p>                          | <p>The Best Leader<br/>The best leaders, the people do not notice.<br/>The next best, the people honor and praise.<br/>The next, the people fear;<br/>and the next, the people hate.<br/>If</p> | <p>First the supreme.<br/>Then a sense of separateness. Next preferences and eulogies. Lastly, fear. Then scorn.<br/>Hence it is plain that lack of sincerity</p>                      | <p>The great rulers - the people do not notice their existence; The lesser ones - they attach to and praise them; The still lesser ones - they fear</p>                     | <p>Politics<br/>The best hierarchy is one those below realize is there.<br/>Next to that<br/>is one that you feel kin to and extol.<br/>Next to that<br/>is one you dread.<br/>Next to that<br/>is one</p>                                                        |
| <p>faith;<br/>It is nurtured on experience.<br/>One following the Sage uses words sparingly,<br/>And lets his natural action speak;<br/>His work is not enslaved to a goal-<br/>Its accomplishment is his statement.<br/>Then progress happens<br/>As if no one had tried.</p> | <p>you have no faith,<br/>people will have no faith in you,<br/>and you must resort to oaths.<br/>When the best leader's work is done<br/>the people say: "We did it ourselves!"</p>            | <p>has its origins in superficial faith.<br/>Cautious! They valued their words, accomplished their purposes, settled their affairs, and the people all said: "We are spontaneous."</p> | <p>them; The still lesser ones - they despise them.<br/>For where faith is lacking, It cannot be met by faith.<br/>Now how much importance must be attributed to words!</p> | <p>you contemn.<br/>When reliability is inadequate in it<br/>There will be unreliability in it.<br/>Reflectively! His ennobling of language.<br/>Works are completed; affairs proceed<br/>And the hundred surnames all call this 'our nature (our own doing)'</p> |

## Chapter 18

Wherever the cosmic order is neglected,  
Goodness and morality are born.  
When the heart's awareness is repressed,  
The intellect is led into hypocrisy.  
When the family loses its natural harmony,  
The rules of duty and honor are enforced.  
When the natural society is disrupted,  
The dragon of state arises,  
And powerful leaders take over.

Nature is sparing in its talk.

High winds seldom  
last all morning.

Heavy rains seldom  
last all day.

Where do these things originate?

The great Tao faded  
and there was  
benevolence and  
righteousness.  
Worldly wisdom and  
shrewdness appeared  
and there was much  
dissembling.

## The family

When the great Tao  
is lost, spring forth  
benevolence and  
righteousness.

When wisdom and sagacity arise, there are great hypocrites.

When family relations are no longer harmonious, we have filial

## The Origin of Ethical Concepts

When the great guide is cast aside you will have 'humanity' and 'morality.'

When intuitive wisdom emerges you will have great artifice.

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In nature.

And if nature so  
spares its talk,

how much more,  
then, should you?

relationships no longer harmonious, there was filial piety and paternal love.

The state and the  
clans in anarchy,  
there was loyalty and  
faithfulness.

children and devoted  
parents.

When a nation is in confusion and disorder, patriots are recognized. Where Tao is, equilibrium is. When Tao is lost, out come all the differences of things.

When great kinship  
is not in harmony,  
you will have  
'filiality' and  
'affection.'

When states and great families sink and become deranged, you will have 'loyal ministers.'

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| <p>Separate from spirituality;<br/>Extinguish wisdom,<br/>And there will be benefit for all.<br/>Discard all pretence<br/>To piety and benevolence,<br/>And the people will help one another.<br/>Close the academies;<br/>Extirpate the feudal rites,<br/>And sorrow will be annihilated.<br/>Banish investment vehicles,<br/>Impoverish the</p> | <p>On Real Education<br/>Do away with learning, the same with wisdom;<br/>the people will gain a hundredfold.<br/>Do away with "humanity" and the same with "justice";<br/>the people will rediscover love and duty.<br/>Do away with expensive arts, the same with profits;<br/>there will be no thieves, no robbers.<br/>These three things involve the external world;<br/>they are therefore of no real value.<br/>Do away with</p>                  | <p>Abandon knowledge, discard wisdom – the people will gain a hundred fold.<br/>Abandon the humanities, discard righteousness – the people will return to filial love.<br/>Abandon cleverness, discard gain – robbers and</p>                              | <p>Do away with sageness and eject wisdom, and the people will be more benefited a hundred times.<br/>Do away with learning, and grief will not be known.<br/>Do away with benevolence and eject righteousness, and the people will return to filial duty and parental love.<br/>Do</p>                  | <p>Argument for Ethical Anarchism<br/>Terminate 'sageliness', junk 'wisdom'<br/>the people will benefit a hundred-fold.<br/>Terminate 'humanity', junk 'morality'<br/>the people will respond with 'filiality' and 'affection.'<br/>Terminate 'artistry', junk 'benefit'<br/>thieves and robbers will lack</p> |
| <p>profit-takers,<br/>And there will be neither thieves nor frauds.<br/>These are the ornaments of my teaching,<br/>But hardly the essence, which is this:<br/>Rely upon your inner discernment;<br/>Return to your original purity;<br/>Wear down your ego;<br/>Break out of the circle of desire.</p>                                           | <p>formal learning and<br/>you will not be annoyed by its multitude of details.<br/>How much difference between yes and yea?<br/>How much difference between good and evil?<br/>It is true that what men fear you must also fear,<br/>but how very remote the actual occurrence.<br/>The people need what is more dependable.<br/>Reveal, then, your natural, inner self.<br/>Realize your original nature;<br/>control selfishness; subdue desires.</p> | <p>thieves will be no more.<br/>These three, being considered not sufficiently aesthetic, therefore many other devices were added.<br/>Better observe simplicity, encourage primitiveness, lessen the number of private projects, and moderate desire.</p> | <p>away with artifice and eject gains, and there will be no robbers and thieves.<br/>These four, if we consider them as culture, are not sufficient.<br/>Therefore let there be what the people can resort to: Appear in plainness and hold to simplicity; Restrain selfishness and curtail desires.</p> | <p>'existence'.<br/>These three taken as slogans are insufficient.<br/>Hence, leads us to postulate that to which they belong.<br/>Visualize simplicity and embrace uncarved wood.<br/>Downgrade 'selfishness' and diminish 'desire.'<br/>Terminate learning and you will lack irritation.</p>                 |

## Chapter 20

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| <p>Shut down your intellect, and answer:</p> <p>Between yes and no, spoken from within,</p> <p>How little a difference is there,</p> <p>Compared to that between success and failure?</p> <p>Why would I fear what others do?</p> <p>Why must I give my inner consent</p> <p>To the values of the collective?</p> <p>Oh! How the desolation around me</p> <p>Has reached its utmost sunken limit!</p> <p>The lusty mob is buried in busyness,</p> <p>As if gathered for a sacrificial feast</p> <p>(Yet who or what is being sacrificed?)</p> <p>But I alone-as if from an outpost of vigilance-</p> | <p>The great mass of people are content</p> <p>as if at the sacrificial feast</p> <p>or at the spring carnival.</p> <p>I alone am serene, quiet, passive,</p> <p>like a newborn baby unable yet to smile.</p> <p>I am alone, like one who is homeless.</p> <p>Others seem to have abundance</p> <p>while I seem to live in contemplation.</p> <p>Perhaps I am the fool, so</p> | <p>Scholarship abandoned, sorrow vanishes.</p> <p>Yes and yea, are they not almost alike?</p> <p>Goodness and evil, are they not akin?</p> <p>Untrammeled and without limits – yet that may not be lightly esteemed which all men reverence.</p> <p>The multitude are joyful and merry – as though feasting on a day of sacrifice, or ascending a high tower in spring. I alone am anchored without giving any sign – like an infant, undeveloped.</p> <p>My homeless heart wanders among the things of sense, as if it had nowhere to stay.</p> <p>The multitude have</p> | <p>Between yea and nay, how much difference is there? Between good and evil, how much difference is there?</p> <p>What are feared by others we must fear; Vastly are they unlimited!</p> <p>The people in general are as happy as if enjoying a great feast. Or, as going up a tower in spring. I alone am tranquil, and have made no signs, Like a baby who is yet unable to smile; Forlorn as if I had no home to go to.</p> <p>Others all have more than enough, And I alone seem to be in want.</p> | <p>Left without Language</p> <p>How much separates</p> <p>'Uh huh' and 'Huh uh'?</p> <p>What is the separation like between</p> <p>'worthy' and 'vile'?</p> <p>What humans fear cannot not be feared.</p> <p>Futile! Not focused yet.</p> <p>The crowd festive</p> <p>--like enjoying an Easter picnic</p> <p>or on an Easter sunrise hike.</p> <p>I, alone, am placid--it's portent not yet clear.</p> <p>Like an infant not yet a baby.</p> <p>Languorous!</p> <p>Like having no refuge.</p> <p>The crowd all have plenty</p> |
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| <p>obscure, so vague.</p> <p>The masses seem bright and informed;</p> <p>I alone seem dull and uninformed.</p> <p>The masses are clever and smug;</p> <p>I alone am simple and unassuming.</p> <p>Alone, as if adrift on the lonely sea.</p> <p>And others seem to have useful purpose;</p> <p>I alone seem impractical and awkward.</p> <p>I am alone, different.</p> <p>I choose to be sustained by nature.</p> | <p>enough and to spare – I alone am as one who has lost something.</p> <p>Have I then the mind of a fool? Am I so very confused?</p> <p>Ordinary men are bright enough. I alone am dull.</p> <p>Ordinary men are full of excitement. I alone am heavy-hearted.</p> <p>Boundless as the sea, drifting to and fro, as if without a place to rest.</p> <p>All men have some purpose. I alone am thick-headed as a boor.</p> <p>I am alone – differing from others, in that I reverence and seek the Nursing Mother.</p> | <p>Possibly mine is the mind of a fool, Which is so ignorant!</p> <p>The vulgar are bright, And I alone seem to be dull. The vulgar are discriminative, and I alone seem blunt. I am negligent as if being obscure; Drifting, as if being attached to nothing.</p> | <p>I alone treat it as loss.</p> <p>Mine is the heart-mind of the stupid, indeed.</p> <p>Indiscriminate!</p> <p>People of custom are lustrous,</p> <p>I alone am dull.</p> <p>People of custom are critically discriminating;</p> <p>I alone obfuscate.</p> <p>Bland! It's like the ocean; drifting! like I have no place to stop.</p> <p>The crowd all have the-capacity-to</p> <p>and I alone am dallying and wanton.</p> <p>I alone am different from humans,</p> <p>and value nursing at Mother's breast.</p> |
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## Chapter 21

The greatness of modesty is fulfilled  
In harmony with the Cosmic Source.  
Its nature seems elusive, ephemeral;  
It is evanescent, indefinable;  
But only because its action is unforced.  
It is the very center of the self,  
Yet we don't know where it is.  
It is the active voice of being:  
Formless, and impenetrable to thought,  
Yet manifest in every natural act  
Through the furthest memory of Time.  
It never arrives, never departs;  
Its expression fulfills Nature.  
It is the child of discernment,

The Teh follows Tao.  
Tao is like a dream:  
invisible, intangible,  
obscure.

It is invisible yet  
there is a form to it.

It is intangible yet  
there is a feel to it.

It is obscure yet there  
is method to it.

The comprehensiveness of supreme energy is its conformity to the Tao.

The Tao considered as an entity is impalpable, indefinite. Indefinite, impalpable, within are concretions.

Impalpable, indefinite, within are shapes. Profound, obscure, within there is essence.

The great virtue as manifested is but following Tao.

Tao is a thing that is both invisible and intangible.

Guiding and the Physical

The content of permeating virtuosity is merely following a guide.

To deem guides as a natural kind:

Indeed confused!  
Indeed indistinct!

Indistinct! Confused!

Within them there are signs.

Confused! Indistinct!

Within them there are natural kinds.

Yawning! Murky!

Within

The method is true  
and so there are signs  
of it.

From ancient times  
until now  
the signs have never  
ceased

by which we can still  
see the beginning.

How can I know the  
nature of the  
beginning?

By these signs!

This essence being supremely real, within is sincerity.

From the beginning until now it has not changed, and thus it has watched all the essentials. How do I know it has been thus will all principles? By what has just been said.

Intangible and invisible, yet there are forms in it;  
Invisible and intangible, yet there is substance in it;  
Subtle and obscure, there is essence in it;  
This essence being invariably true, there is faith in it.

From of old till now, it has never lost its (nameless) name,  
Through which the origin of all things has passed.

How do I know that it is so with the origin of all things? By this (Tao).

them there is  
generative energy.

Their energy is  
optimally authentic.

Within it there is  
reliability.

From the past to the  
present

it's name remains.

And elucidates the  
crowd's honored  
father.

How do I know the  
shape of the crowd's  
honored father?

With this.

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| <p>Yield to the outer, and you remain</p> <p>Firm and complete within.</p> <p>Appear crooked to others,</p> <p>But be straight and true within.</p> <p>Empty yourself, and be made full;</p> <p>Strip yourself of excess</p> <p>And you will know true rejuvenation.</p> <p>Thus does diminishment attract abundance,</p> <p>While accumulation nurtures conflict.</p> <p>Therefore the student of the Sage</p> <p>Holds humility in his arms;</p> <p>It protects and supports him.</p> <p>In refusing to display his insight,</p> <p>He validates his true nature.</p> <p>He takes no credit, and makes no claim;</p> | <p>Be humble; you will remain yourself.</p> <p>Be flexible, bend, and you will be straight.</p> <p>Be ever receptive, and you will be satisfied.</p> <p>Become tired and weary and you will be renewed.</p> <p>Have little, you will have enough;</p> <p>to have abundance is to be troubled.</p> <p>The truly wise seek Unity, embrace oneness,</p> <p>and become examples for all</p> | <p>To be crooked is to be perfected; to be bent is to be straightened; to be lowly is to be filled; to be senile is to be renewed; to be diminished is to be able to receive; to be increased is to be deluded.</p> <p>Therefore the Holy Man embraces unity, and becomes the world's model.</p> <p>He is not self-regarding, therefore he is cognizant.</p> | <p>'Be humble, and you will remain entire.'</p> <p>Be bent, and you will remain straight. Be vacant, and you will remain full. Be worn, and you will remain new. He who has little will receive. He who has much will be embarrassed.</p> <p>Therefore the Sage keeps to One and becomes the standard for the world.</p> <p>He does not display himself; therefore he shines.</p> | <p>The Point to Reversal?</p> <p>If 'crooked' then 'intact'</p> <p>If 'twisted' then 'straight'</p> <p>If 'vacuous' then 'filled'</p> <p>If 'worn out' then 'new'</p> <p>If 'deficient' then 'endowed'</p> <p>If 'endowed' then 'confounded'</p> <p>Using this: Sages embrace one</p> <p>and deem it the social world's model.</p> <p>He doesn't see by himself hence is perceptive.</p> |
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| <p>his only luster.</p> <p>Therefore, he neither boasts nor flatters.</p> <p>He seeks no merit,</p> <p>Pursues no goal,</p> <p>Accepts no praise;</p> <p>And thus he enduringly succeeds.</p> <p>He contends not with man or nature,</p> <p>And so no one can defeat him.</p> <p>Thus the ancient teaching lives</p> <p>Within this very moment:</p> <p>"Drop your burden, abandon the superficial,</p> <p>And you will find your perfect center."</p> <p>This was not a shallow teaching.</p> <p>Release your true nature;</p> <p>Express your inner being;</p> <p>Return to the Source.</p> | <p>the world.</p> <p>Not revealing themselves, they shine;</p> <p>not self-righteous, they are distinguished;</p> <p>not self-centered, they are famous;</p> <p>not seeking glory, they are leaders.</p> <p>Because they are not quarrelsome</p> <p>no one quarrels with them.</p> <p>Thus it is as the ancients said:</p> <p>"To yield is to retain Unity."</p> <p>The truly wise have Unity,</p> | <p>He is not egotistic, therefore he is distinguished.</p> <p>He is not boastful, therefore he has merit.</p> <p>He is not conceited, therefore he is superior.</p> <p>Inasmuch as he strives with none, there are none in the world able to strive with him.</p> <p>That ancient maxim – "To be crooked is to become perfected" – was it an idle word? Verily, it includes the whole.</p> | <p>He does not approve himself; therefore he is noted. He does not praise himself; therefore he has merit. He does not glory in himself; therefore he excels.</p> <p>And because he does not compete; therefore no one in the world can compete with him.</p> <p>The ancient saying 'Be humble and you will remain entire' - Can this be regarded as mere empty words? Indeed he shall return home entire.</p> | <p>discerning.</p> <p>Doesn't attack by himself hence has success.</p> <p>Doesn't esteem himself hence becomes an elder.</p> <p>In general: he does not dispute</p> <p>hence in the social world none is able to dispute with him.</p> <p>The ancients who said 'If 'crooked' then 'intact'--</p> <p>could they have offered empty words?</p> <p>Take 'intact' as sincere and return to it.</p> |
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Be sparing in your speech,  
And then return to silence.

Be truly a part of Nature:  
Its storm-brought winds do  
not outlast the dawn;

Its rain drums and sings  
upon the thirsty earth,  
And then the clouds recede  
before the sun.

What made this dance of  
sound and silence?

If the Cosmic  
Consciousness thus ebbs  
and flows,

Why not we, the  
word-drunk wanderers of  
this world?

Therefore, the student of  
the Sage

Steps mindfully through his  
life:

He allows the Cosmic

Whoever follows Tao  
becomes as Tao.

Whoever follows Teh  
becomes as Teh.

Whoever abandons  
Tao or Teh  
will be abandoned by  
Tao

Few words are  
natural.

A whirlwind does not  
outlast the morning;  
a deluge does not  
outlast the day. Who  
produces these? The  
Heaven-Earth. If the  
Heaven-Earth cannot  
produce lasting  
phenomena, how  
much less can man?

Wherefore settling  
everything in  
accordance with the  
Tao, embodying the  
Tao they become  
identified with the  
Tao.

To be sparing of  
words is natural. A  
violent wind cannot  
last a whole morning;  
pelting rain cannot  
last a whole day.

Who have made  
these things but  
heaven and earth?  
Inasmuch as heaven  
and earth cannot last  
forever, how can  
man?

He who engages  
himself in Tao is  
identified with Tao.

The Constancy of  
Guiding Concepts

Rare language is our  
own doing.

Hence a twisting  
wind does not end  
the morning.

A sudden storm does  
not end the day.

What makes these  
the case?--the  
cosmos.

The cosmos can raise  
it but cannot make it  
endure.

How much more is  
this the case with the  
human realm?

Hence those who  
pursue affairs with  
'guidance'

Voice

To speak through his  
actions,

And so he need not talk  
himself.

Modesty is the golden  
thread of the Cosmic  
tapestry.

It is the active mode of  
Nature:

The breath of bliss in life.

Modesty acts through  
renunciation:

It abandons identification.

In exploding the image,  
It liberates the self.

In dropping comparison,  
It inaugurates autonomy  
and lets loose joy.

As you learn, ask yourself:

"Is my life founded on mere  
faith,

and Teh.

Whoever seeks Tao  
is welcomed by Tao.

Whoever seeks Teh  
is welcomed by Teh.

Whoever seeks  
abandonment  
is welcomed by  
abandonment.

Embodying its virtue,  
they become  
identified with virtue.

Embodying loss, they  
become identified  
with loss.

Identified with Tao,  
they joyfully accept  
the Tao; identified  
with virtue, they  
joyfully accept  
virtue; identified  
with loss, they  
joyfully accept loss.

If sincerity is lacking  
it is because of  
superficial faith.

He who engages  
himself in virtue is  
identified with virtue.

He who engages  
himself in  
abandonment is  
identified with  
abandonment.

Identified with Tao  
he will be well  
received by Tao.

Identified with virtue  
he will be well  
received by virtue.

Identified with  
abandonment he will  
be well received by  
abandonment.

Those of 'guidance,'  
join in guidance.

Those of 'virtuosity,'  
join in virtuosity.

Those of 'loss,' join  
in loss.

Those who join in  
guidance, guidance is  
pleased to get them.

Those who join in  
virtuosity, virtuosity  
is pleased to get  
them.

Those who join in  
loss, loss is pleased  
to get them.

When reliability is  
inadequate in it

There will be  
unreliability in it.





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| <p>There is something whole and formless,</p> <p>That existed before any universe was born.</p> <p>It makes no sound,</p> <p>Has no substance,</p> <p>Can't be fixed in time or space-</p> <p>It is inexhaustible, unchanging, perduring:</p> <p>It is the uterus of being,</p> <p>And I call it Tao,</p> <p>Just so it has a home in my mind.</p> <p>It may also be called the great,</p> <p>Since all beings arise from it,</p> <p>And it is the home to which they return.</p> <p>Nature is great;</p> <p>The sky is great;</p> <p>The earth is great;</p> <p>Even humans can be great.</p> | <p>There is something mysterious,</p> <p>without beginning, without end,</p> <p>that existed before the heavens and earth.</p> <p>Unmoving; infinite; standing alone; never changing.</p> <p>It is everywhere and it is inexhaustible.</p> <p>It is the mother of all.</p> <p>I do not know its name.</p> <p>If I must name it I call it Tao</p> <p>and I hail it as supreme.</p> <p>Supreme means never-ending;</p> <p>never-ending means far-reaching;</p> <p>and —</p> | <p>There was a completed, amorphous something before the Heaven-Earth was born. Tranquil! Boundless!</p> <p>Abiding alone and changing not! Extending everywhere without risk. It may be styled "the world-mother."</p> <p>I do not know its name, but characterize it – tao Tao. Arbitrarily forcing a name upon it I call it the Great.</p> <p>Great, it may be said to be transitory.</p> | <p>There is a thing inherent and natural, Which existed before heaven and earth. Motionless and fathomless, It stands alone - and never changes; It pervades everywhere and never becomes exhausted. It may be regarded as the Mother of the Universe.</p> <p>I do not know its name. If I am forced to give it a name, I call it Tao, and I name it as supreme.</p> <p>Supreme</p> | <p>What's behind it all?</p> <p>There is a thing-kind made up of a mix.</p> <p>It emerges before the cosmos.</p> <p>Solitary! Inchoate!</p> <p>Self grounded and unchanging.</p> <p>Permeating all processes without extremity.</p> <p>We can deem it the mother of the social world.</p> <p>I don't know its name. When put in characters we say dao.</p> <p>Forced to deem it as named, we say 'great.'</p> <p>Being great, we say 'comprehensive.'</p> |
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True darkness seems to be light;  
Indeed, it is the origin of light.  
The enduring tranquility  
May appear to be agitated:  
For it is the apogee of agitation.  
Thus wandering all the livelong day,  
The student of the Sage  
Stays as still as can be—  
Unmoved by the attraction of glory,  
Or the titillation of diversion.  
Even stopping amid the feast,  
His independence is unshakeable.  
Could this be said of the political insider,  
Who so lightly drops his dignity  
For every passing pleasure?

Heaviness (sincerity)  
is the root of  
lightness (frivolity).  
And serenity far  
surpasses hastiness.  
The truly wise can  
travel all day  
yet never put down  
their baggage  
(a pun alluding to  
depth or heaviness of  
spirit).  
Though there

Lightness has its roots in heaviness. Restlessness has a master in stillness. Therefore, the Holy Man travels all day without leaving the baggage wagon. Surrounded by sensuous enjoyments he remains peaceful and free.

Heaviness is the basis of lightness; Calmness is the controlling power of hastiness.

Therefore the Sage, though traveling all day long, Never separates from his baggage-wagon; Though surrounded with magnificent sights, He lives in tranquillity.

Ambiguous  
Reversals

Deem 'heavy' as root  
of 'light'

Deem 'calm' as lord  
of 'uproar'.

Using this: Sages  
pass the whole day in  
activity

and never separate  
from his heavy  
provisions cart.

Even though he has  
an sublime views,

be appealing  
distractions  
they remain serene,  
passive, undisturbed.  
How can a leader of  
ten thousand chariots  
make his rule  
obscure,  
insignificant?  
To be light is to lose  
the root of lightness;  
to be hasty is to lose  
self-mastery.

How, then, can the Lord of ten thousand chariots regard his personality as of less importance than his royal trust? By levity he will lose his ministers; by restlessness he will lose his throne.

How is it, then, that a king of ten thousand chariots Should conduct himself so lightly in the empire? To be light is to lose the basis; To be hasty is to lose the controlling power.

surpassing those  
where swallows  
dwell.

What do we say,  
then,  
of the 10,000 chariot  
ruler  
who, based on the  
self, 'lights' the social  
world?

To 'light' is to lose  
the root.

To 'uproar' is to lose  
the lord.

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| <p>Treading correctly, we leave no trace.</p> <p>Correct speech is brief and true.</p> <p>Correct assessment is ever open-</p> <p>Calculation does not further it.</p> <p>The true-fitting door is shut fast</p> <p>Without need of bar or latch-</p> <p>Yet none can break its seal,</p> <p>Or cross its threshold.</p> <p>The best knots tie firmly,</p> <p>Yet without binding: such connections</p> <p>Can never be broken from outside.</p> <p>Thus the eternal Sage</p> <p>Acts with abiding care for all.</p> <p>Because of this, it abandons no one:</p> <p>Its regenerative Presence flows</p> | <p>A good traveler has no need to leave tracks;</p> <p>a good speaker leaves no grounds for rebuttal;</p> <p>a good trader needs no scales, no computer;</p> <p>a good door needs no latch to remain shut;</p> <p>a good fastener needs no rope to perfect its bond.</p> <p>The truly wise are helpful to people.</p> <p>No</p> | <p>Good does leave no tracks. True words have no defects. Skillful plans require no calculations. Able closers need no locks and bars, yet none can open what they shut. Real strength wants no cords, yet none can loose it.</p> <p>It follows that the Holy Man when helping others, works in accordance with the unchanging goodness.</p> <p>Hence, he rejects none.</p> | <p>A good traveler leaves no track; A good speaker leaves no error; A good reckoner needs no counter;</p> <p>A good closer needs no bars or bolts, And yet it is impossible to open after him. A good fastener needs no cords or knots, And yet it is impossible to untie after him.</p> <p>Even if men be bad, why should they be rejected?</p> | <p>Paradoxes of the Greatest Skill</p> <p>Worthy travel lacks ruts and footprints.</p> <p>Worthy language lacks flaws and reproach.</p> <p>Worthy tallying doesn't use algorithms.</p> <p>Worthy closing lacks bars and bolts</p> <p>and still can't be opened.</p> <p>Worthy securing lacks rope or restraint</p> <p>and still can't be loosed.</p> <p>Using this: Sages take saving humanity as a constant</p> <p>hence</p> |
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| <p>Acknowledge the masculine</p> <p>And be one with the feminine:</p> <p>Let the river of your being flow</p> <p>Into the valley of eternal Nature.</p> <p>The path of Modesty is true and complete:</p> <p>Ever returning to the origin,</p> <p>As a child returns to its mother.</p> <p>Acknowledge the white,</p> <p>But trust in the black:</p> <p>Let Nature be the mold</p> <p>Into which you pour</p> <p>The liquid energy of your being.</p> <p>Let Modesty guide you;</p> <p>Perseveringly return to the Source</p> <p>Of limitless serenity.</p> <p>Be aware of your influence,</p> | <p>He who knows the mystic male (Yang)</p> <p>yet retains the mystic female (Yin)</p> <p>is as a great canyon welcoming the whole world.</p> <p>He has Teh and is innocent as a child.</p> <p>Whoever is aware of the white (Yang)</p> <p>yet retains the black (Yin)</p> <p>is as a standard for all the world.</p> <p>He has Teh and has returned to</p> | <p>One conscious of virility, maintaining muliebrity, is a world-channel. From a world-channel the unchanging energy never departs. This is to revert to the state of infancy.</p> <p>One conscious of brightness, placid in shade, is a world-model. In a world-model the unchanging energy remains undiminished.</p> | <p>He who knows the masculine and yet keeps to the feminine Will become a channel drawing all the world towards it; Being a channel of the world, he will not be severed from the eternal virtue, And then he can return again to the state of infancy.</p> <p>He who knows the white and yet keeps to the black Will become the standard of the world; Being the standard of the world, with him eternal virtue will never falter,</p> | <p>Opposites and Primitivism</p> <p>To know its 'male' and preserve its 'female'</p> <p>is to act as the world's ravine.</p> <p>To act as the world' ravine,</p> <p>treat virtuosity as constant, and avoid separating</p> <p>is to return to infancy.</p> <p>To know its 'white' and preserve its 'black'</p> <p>is to act as the world's paradigm.</p> <p>To act as the world's paradigm,</p> |
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To those who would  
alter Nature,  
Or spread reform upon  
the earth,  
I say this: though your  
efforts be endless,  
You will not succeed.  
Alteration, control,  
improvement:  
They are repugnant to  
Nature,  
For perfection  
requires no  
refinement.  
The impulse to control  
Only deforms what  
you wish to manage.  
Thus, it is lost to you.  
This is a principle

Those who seek to  
conquer the world  
and shape it as they  
see fit never succeed.  
The world is a sacred  
vessel and cannot be  
improved.  
Whoever tries to alter  
it spoils it;  
whoever tries to

I perceive that no  
desire can succeed  
which has as its  
objective the  
moulding of the state.  
The state possesses a  
divine capacity,  
which cannot be  
moulded.  
To make is to mar; to

When a man is to  
take the world over  
and shape it, I see  
that he must be  
obliged to do it.  
For the world is a  
divine vessel: It  
cannot be shaped;  
Nor can it be insisted  
upon. He who shapes  
it damages it; He  
who insists upon it  
loses it.  
Therefore the Sage  
does not shape it, so  
he does not damage  
it; 'He does not insist  
upon it, so he does  
not lose it.

Deeming  
Those who desire to  
take the social world  
and deem-act it,  
I see that they just  
don't get it.  
The social world is  
an energized artifact.  
It is not the case that  
it can be deemed.  
Those

that all can use:  
Sometimes it leads  
and sometimes  
follows;  
Sometimes it breathes  
in and sometimes out;  
Sometimes it is  
growing, sometimes  
diminishing;  
Sometimes it builds  
up, sometimes it  
collapses.  
This is the way things  
are.  
Thus the Sage  
withdraws from  
excess,  
And retreats from  
display.  
Where arrogance  
boasts,

direct it, misleads it.  
So, some things  
advance, others lag;  
some proceed in  
silence, others make  
sound;  
some are strong,  
others weak;  
some are forward,  
others retiring.  
Therefore the truly  
wise avoid extremes,  
extravagance, and  
foolish pride.

grasp is to lose.  
Thus in nature some  
things lead, others  
follow; some inspire,  
others expire; some  
are strong, some are  
weak; some survive,  
others succumb;  
hence, the Holy Man  
renounces excess,  
extravagance,  
exaltation.

'For, among all  
things, some go  
ahead, while others  
lag behind; Some  
keep their mouth  
shut, while others  
give forth puffs;  
Some are strong,  
while others are  
weak; Some are on  
the cart, while others  
fall off.  
Therefore the Sage  
avoids excess,  
extravagance and  
indulgence.

who deem-act crush  
it.  
Those who grasp lose  
it.  
Hence, among  
natural kinds  
sometimes act,  
sometimes conform.  
sometimes snort  
sometimes blow.  
sometimes be strong  
sometimes weak.  
sometimes control  
sometimes destroy.  
Using this: Sages  
abandon superlatives,  
abandon  
extravagance,



who glorify it--  
that is to take satisfaction in  
killing.

If you take satisfaction in  
killing,  
you cannot take that as  
filling the intent of the  
social world.

Auspicious affairs favor the  
left,  
inauspicious the right.

The lower-rank general is  
on the left  
and the higher rank on the  
right.

These words amount to  
arranging them according  
to the funeral rite.

Killing peoples in crowds,  
we cry for them in bitter  
grief.

With victory in war we  
arrange things according to  
the funeral rite.

## Chapter 32

Brian Donohue

C. Ganson

C. Spurgeon Medhurst

Ch'u Ta-Kao

Chad Hansen

The Cosmic Whole, in all its breadth,  
Surpasses its name.  
Its crystalline simplicity  
Is so inexpressibly minute  
That no human mind can grasp it.  
If only political leaders and corporate barons  
Could apprehend its nature,  
Then the complementarity of limitless beings  
Would effortlessly arise and endure.  
In such loving attraction live earth and sky:  
As when blessed rain falls soft upon the earth,  
Mankind and Nature could unite like lovers-  
Free of law, free of command,  
People would finally be

Tao is absolute, nameless.  
A piece of wood, uncarved, natural,  
cannot be used by anyone.  
The leaders who can be genuine and natural as this,  
gain the respect of the people.  
The heavens and the earth join and gentle rains fall,

Tao – the Eternally Nameless.  
Though primordial simplicity is infinitesimal, none dare make it a public servant.  
Were princes and monarchs able to maintain it, all creation would spontaneously submit.  
Heaven and earth harmonized, there would be an abundance of nourishing agencies; the people unbidden,

When for the first time applied to function, it was named.

A Natural Guide.  
Guide by treating nameless uncarved wood as constant.  
Although small,  
none in the social world can treat it as vassal.  
If fief-holding kings could embrace it,  
all the natural kinds would come to self conformity.  
Heaven and earth mutually coalesce to rain down sweet dew.  
The people, no one ordering

at peace.  
Through names are things distinguished,  
And through names can they be exhausted.  
The outcome depends on balance:  
Feeling where the word is true,  
And when it has reached its limit.  
Correct approach comes from the center.  
In balance, too, is Tao expressed  
In the life of our world:  
The stream extends to the river,  
The river extends to the sea,  
The sea extends to the ocean,  
The ocean extends to the world.

beyond anyone's command, to everyone equally.  
When civilization grew, names began.  
With names, one should know where to stop.  
Whoever knows this has security.  
In the world Tao is like rain  
that falls into the rivers  
and thence to the open sea.

would cooperate of their own accord.  
Names arose when differentiation commenced; once there were names it became important to know where to stop.  
This being known, danger ceased.  
The Tao spread throughout the world, may be compared to mountain rivulets and streams flowing toward the sea.

In as much as names are given, one should also know where to stop. Knowing where to stop one can become imperishable.  
Tao was always nameless.

them, self balance.  
To begin to restrain you have names.  
As soon as you have names then,  
in general, you must also come to know to stop.  
If you know to stop, you can avoid danger.  
Compare this guide's being in the social world  
to the relation of brook valleys to rivers and oceans.



Study mankind, for this is wisdom.  
But first examine yourself, for this is penetration.  
To subjugate others, it takes power.  
But defeating your own ego  
Needs the gentle strength of perseverance.  
Acknowledge the wealth within you,  
And you won't need to strive for more.  
But grasp

One who knows others is wise;  
one who knows himself is wisest.  
One who conquers others is strong;  
one who conquers himself is strongest.  
To be

Who knows men has discernment; who knows himself has illumination.  
Who overcomes men has strength; who overcomes himself has determination.

He who knows others is wise; He who knows himself is enlightened.  
He who conquers others is strong; He who conquers himself is mighty.  
He who knows contentment is rich.

Achievable goals.  
Those who know the human are wise.  
The self-knowing are discerning.  
Those who triumph among the human have power.  
The self-triumphing are coercive.  
Those

after the brass ring,  
And you become a conformist  
In a society of willful pursuit.  
The one who can remain in the center  
Will endure beyond the reach of time.  
For though he may die to the visible,  
His life continues in immanence.  
Thus, he is immortal.

content is to be wealthy.  
To be dedicated is to be strong.  
To be genuine is to endure.  
To die and be remembered is to have immortality.

Who knows contentment has wealth.  
Who acts vigorously has will.  
Who never departs from his base, endures long; he dies, but does not perish; he lives eternally.

He who keeps on his course with energy has will.  
He who does not deviate from his proper place will long endure. He who may die but not perish has longevity.

who know sufficiency are affluent.  
Those who coercively act have will.  
Those who don't lose their 'that-which' are long-lasting  
Those who die and don't disappear are long-lived.

Sublime, the Cosmic Breath  
That limitlessly pervades and  
imbues  
Time and space, form and  
non-form.  
It diffuses in every direction,  
It flows through all being,  
It creates and furthers all,  
But makes no claim and takes  
no credit.  
It is the body of  
transformation,  
And we do not even know its  
name!  
It loves and nourishes  
The infinite family of forms,  
But seeks not allegiance or  
submission.  
Eternally free of abstraction,  
Its name may be sought  
Within the realm of the  
infinitesimal,  
Though it is the origin and  
destiny

The great Tao is everywhere, on all sides.

Everything derives from it;  
nothing is rejected by it.

Through Tao everything exists  
yet it does not take possession.

It provides

Supreme is the Tao!  
All pervasive; it can  
be on the left hand  
and on the right.

All things depend on  
it for life, and it  
denies none.

Its purposes  
accomplished, it  
claims no credit.

It clothes and fosters  
all things, but

The great Tao pervades everywhere, both on the left and on the right.

By it all things came into being, and it does not reject them. Merits accomplished, it does not possess them.

The Great Guide  
The great guide is everywhere!  
Thus it can 'left' the 'right.'  
The ten-thousand natural kinds depend on it and thus live.  
And it does not phrase its guidance.  
Success is achieved and not named as 'having.'  
Supports and nourishes the ten-thousand natural kinds  
and does not deem-act as

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for everything  
yet it does not lay  
claim.

Without motive it  
seems small.

Being the source of  
everything it is great.

Because it never  
claims greatness,  
its greatness shines  
brightly.

claims no lordship. Ever desireless, it may be named "The Indivisible."

All things revert to it, but it claims no lordship. It may be named "The Supreme."

Because to the end it does not seek supremacy; it is able to accomplish great things.

It loves and nourishes all things but does not dominate over them. It is always non-existent; therefore it can be named as small. All things return home to it, and it does not claim mastery over them; therefore it can be named as great. Because it never assumes greatness, therefore it can accomplish greatness.

lord.

Treating lack of desire as constant; it can be named in the direction of 'small.'

The ten-thousand natural kinds return to it and it does not deem-act as lord.

It can be named as 'great.'

With its ultimately not self-deeming as 'great'

Hence it is able to achieve its 'great.'

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| <p>Take to your heart<br/>The hand of the great<br/>Cosmic Teacher,<br/>And your deepest<br/>true nature<br/>Will arise in a peace<br/>beyond harm-<br/>Joyfully harmonizing<br/>with the eternal<br/>abundance.<br/>The wanderer tarries<br/>at the lilt of a song<br/>Or the smell of good<br/>cooking;</p> | <p>The world will<br/>follow, without fear<br/>of evil,<br/>serene, peaceful,<br/>secure,<br/>one who follows the<br/>great symbol of<br/>Yin-Yang.<br/>Music and good food<br/>will stop the passing</p>                     | <p>Apprehend the<br/>inimitable<br/>conception, you<br/>attract the world;<br/>coming it receives no<br/>harm, but it tranquil,<br/>peaceful, satisfied.<br/>Like transient guests,<br/>music and dainties<br/>pass away.<br/>The</p> | <p>To him who holds to<br/>the Great Form all<br/>the world will go. It<br/>will go and see no<br/>danger, but<br/>tranquillity, equality<br/>and community.<br/>Music and dainties<br/>will make the passing<br/>stranger stop.<br/>But Tao when uttered<br/>in words is so pure<br/>and void of flavour<br/>When one looks at it,<br/>one cannot see it;<br/>When one listens to<br/>it, one cannot hear it.</p> | <p>Great Guiding Signs?<br/>Grasp great signs.<br/>The social world<br/>moves.<br/>If it move and does<br/>not harm,<br/>the comfort and<br/>balance is supreme.<br/>Concerts and feasts<br/>bring passing guests<br/>to a halt.</p> |
| <p>But the lyric from the<br/>Cosmic Breath<br/>Falls flat upon the<br/>ear,<br/>As its words are<br/>flavorless to the<br/>tongue.<br/>The eye can scarce<br/>perceive it,<br/>The ear discerns only<br/>the echo-<br/>For it lies deep<br/>within,<br/>And you never get<br/>tired of using it.</p>         | <p>stranger,<br/>but Tao, offered by<br/>the spoken word,<br/>seems unappealing,<br/>tasteless.<br/>Looked for, it cannot<br/>be seen;<br/>listened for, it cannot<br/>be heard;<br/>applied, it cannot be<br/>exhausted.</p> | <p>Tao entering the<br/>mouth is insipid and<br/>without flavour;<br/>when looked at it<br/>evades sight; when<br/>listened for it escapes<br/>the ear – (yet) its<br/>operations are<br/>interminable.</p>                           | <p>However, when one<br/>uses it, it is<br/>inexhaustible. But we<br/>use it without end.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | <p>Guidance coming out<br/>of the mouth.<br/>Isn't it bland? It lacks<br/>flavor.<br/>Looking at it, it is not<br/>visible.<br/>Listen to it, it is not<br/>audible.<br/>Use it, it is not<br/>applicable.</p>                       |

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| <p>Would you like to reduce it?</p> <p>Then first see it inflated.</p> <p>Would you like it to be weakened?</p> <p>Then first see it as powerful.</p> <p>Would you like to destroy it?</p> <p>Then first see it enshrined.</p> <p>Would you like to drain</p> | <p>Govern Peacefully</p> <p>That which is to contract is first expanded.</p> <p>That which is to weaken is first strengthened.</p> <p>That which is to be felled is first reinforced.</p> | <p>When about to inhale it is certainly necessary to open the mouth; when about to weaken it is certainly necessary to strengthen; when about to discard it is certainly necessary to promote; when about</p> | <p>In order to contract a thing, one should surely expand it first. In order to weaken, one will surely strengthen first. In order to overthrow, one will surely exalt first.</p> | <p>Natural Reversals</p> <p>On the point of desiring to contract it,</p> <p>you must regard it as inherently expanded.</p> <p>On the point of desiring to weaken it,</p> <p>you must regard it as inherently strong.</p> <p>On the point of desiring to dissipate it,</p> <p>you must regard it</p> |
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| <p>it?</p> <p>Then first see it overflow.</p> <p>This is called the subtle discernment:</p> <p>Gently penetrating flexibility</p> <p>Undermines the rigidity of power.</p> <p>A fish can't swim</p> <p>When it's out of its depth;</p> <p>A nation can't survive</p> <p>When it shows off its weaponry.</p> | <p>This is subtle enlightenment.</p> <p>Being gentle overcomes strength.</p> <p>As fish should not leave the deep,</p> <p>so the sharp weapons of the state</p> <p>should always be hidden from view.</p> | <p>to take away it is certainly necessary to impart - this is atomic perception.</p> <p>The weak overcome the strong.</p> <p>Fish cannot leave the deeps.</p> <p>The innerness of the government cannot be shown to the people.</p> | <p>'In order to take, one will surely give first'!</p> <p>This is called subtle wisdom. The soft and weak can overcome the hard and strong.</p> <p>As the fish should not leave the deep So should the sharp implements of a nation not be shown to anyone!</p> | <p>as inherently thriving.</p> <p>On the point of desiring to steal it,</p> <p>you must regard it as inherently belonging.</p> <p>This is called minute discernment.</p> <p>Soft and pliant triumph over hard and coercive.</p> <p>Fish cannot leave the abyss.</p> <p>The state's beneficial artifacts</p> <p>cannot be shown to people.</p> |
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Non-Deeming Action  
Some guide treats  
lacking  
deeming-action as a  
constant  
yet everything is  
deem-acted.  
If fief-holding kings  
could preserve this,  
all the natural kinds  
would come to self  
transformation.  
If they transform and  
desire to construct,  
I will mollify them

with the nameless  
uncarved wood.

Nameless uncarved  
wood is,

in general also being  
on the point of  
lacking desires.

If we use not desiring  
to get calm,

the social world will  
be on the point of  
self-fixing.

Book II

De

virtuosity

[illegible]

## Chapter 39

From before Time as we  
know it was born,  
The experience of Oneness  
with Tao has been.  
To receive the gift of  
Oneness  
Is the way of Nature,  
Manifest in all its forms:  
The open sky and stable  
earth,  
The presence and energy of  
mind.  
Through the One the valley  
fills  
With the life of innumerable  
beings.  
Sometimes, kings and lords  
receive it,  
And are helped in their paths  
of leadership.  
Were sky divorced from  
clarity,  
Then I fear it might collapse  
in darkness,

Lead With a Deep Unity

From past ages there has been Unity:

the heavens achieved it and became clear,  
the earth achieved it and became firm,  
the valleys achieved it and became fertile,  
the spirit achieved it and become inspired,  
all things achieved it and became existent,  
leaders achieved it and became good rulers.

Without clarity the heavens would be tempestuous,  
without firmness the earth

The things which from of old harmonized with the One are: The heavens, which through the One are clear; the earth, which through the One is reposeful; the gods, which through the One are spiritual; space, which through the One is full; whatever has form, which through the One develops; princes and monarchs, which through the One adjust the empire: these are all effects of the One.

Were the heavens not thus clear they would be liable to rend; were the earth thus not reposeful, it would be liable to frothiness; were the gods not thus spiritual, they would be liable to imbecility;

From of old the things that have acquired Unity are these:

Heaven by Unity has become clear;

Earth by Unity has become steady;

The Spirit by Unity has become spiritual;

The Valley by Unity has become full;

All things by Unity have come into existence;

Princes and kings by Unity have become rulers of the world.

If heaven were not clear, it would be rent.

If earth were not steady it would be tumbled down.

If the Spirit were not active, it would pass away.

If the Valley were not full, it would be dried up.

If all things were not existing, they would be extinct.

Achieving Oneness

Things which from the beginning have achieved oneness:

Heaven achieves oneness in being clear.

Earth achieves oneness in stability.

Energy achieves oneness in spirit.

Valleys achieve oneness in filling.

The ten-thousand natural kinds achieve oneness in life.

Fiefholders and Kings achieve oneness in deem-acting to make the social world correct.

They take it to the extreme.

When heaven lacks that with which to become clear,

we're on the point of fearing splitting.

When earth lacks that with which to become stable,

|  |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
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|  | <p>would tremble,<br/>without fertility the<br/>valleys would dry up,<br/>without inspiration the<br/>spirit would be lost,<br/>without existence all<br/>things would vanish,<br/>rulers would falter and<br/>fall.</p> <p>Thus good leaders are<br/>humble.</p> <p>The high are founded<br/>on the low</p> <p>just as a chariot is<br/>made up of many<br/>small parts.</p> <p>Better to rumble like<br/>rocks (have depth)</p> <p>than to jingle lightly<br/>like jewels (be<br/>flighty).</p> |
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were space thus not full, it would be liable to exhaustion; were that which had form not thus developed, it would be liable to annihilation; were princes and monarchs not thus regulated, their dignities and honours would be liable to a downfall.

Hence humility is the root of honour: lowliness the foundation of loftiness. It is on this account that princes and monarchs style themselves "kithless," "friendless," "unworthies." Do they not thus acknowledge humility as their root?

The enumeration of the parts of a carriage no not make a carriage.

Desire neither the polish of the gem, nor the roughness of the stone.

not rulers, they would be overthrown.

The noble must be styled in terms of the humble;

The high must take the low as their foundation.

Therefore princes and kings must call themselves 'the ignorant', 'the virtueless' and 'the unworthy'.

Does this not mean that they take the humble as their root? What men hate most are 'the ignorant', 'the virtueless' and 'the unworthy'.

And yet princes and kings chose them as their titles.

Therefore the highest fame is to have no fame.

Thus kings are increased by being diminished;

They are diminished by being increased.

It is undesirable to be as prominent as a single gem,

Or as monotonously numerous as stones.

Tao in motion is  
returning.

Tao in action is  
accepting.

The vast array of

Tao is an endless  
circle, ever returning.

Serenity is its

The movements of  
the Tao are cyclical;  
the sufficiency of the

Returning is the  
motion of Tao.

Weakness is the  
appliance of Tao.

Reversal

That which is  
converse is the action  
of a guide.

That which is weak is  
the

Nature's forms

Evolves within the  
realm of body,

And the bodily arises  
from the Formless.

ultimate function.

Everything rises  
from existence.

Existence rises from  
non-existence.

Tao is latency.

All that is, exists in  
being, being in  
non-being.

All things in the  
Universe come from  
existence.

And existence from  
non-existence.

use of a guide.

The cosmos and the  
ten-thousand natural  
kinds arise from  
'existing.'

'Existing' arises from  
'non-existing.'



# Chapter 41

Brian Donohue

C. Ganson

C. Spurgeon Medhurst

Ch'u Ta-Kao

Chad Hansen

|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
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| <p>The sincere student hears of Tao,</p> <p>Then sees if he can steadfastly follow it.</p> <p>A casual student hears of Tao</p> <p>And follows it sporadically-</p> <p>Trusting here, and skeptical there.</p> <p>When the self-centered hear of Tao</p> <p>Their laughter fills the air:</p> <p>How could it be Tao</p> <p>If it didn't make them laugh?</p> <p>Therefore is it said:</p> <p>The one with the lantern shines the least.</p> <p>The one making progress seems behind.</p> <p>The easiest path seems tortuous.</p> <p>Natural strength appears weak and hollow.</p> <p>And the greatest virtue seems too small.</p> | <p>Whenever the truly wise hear of Tao</p> <p>they strive earnestly to use it.</p> <p>Whenever the mediocre hear of Tao</p> <p>they are aware, yet unaware of it.</p> <p>Whenever the stupid hear of Tao they laugh aloud at it.</p> <p>If it were not laughed at it would not be Tao.</p> <p>Therefore it is said of Tao:</p> <p>enlightenment seems dullness;</p> <p>progress seems regression;</p> <p>the true path seems</p> | <p>The true student hears of the Tao; he is diligent and practices it.</p> <p>The average student hear of it; sometimes he appears to be attentive, then again he is inattentive.</p> <p>The half hearted student hears of it; he loudly derides it. If it did not provoke ridicule it would not be worthy of the name – Tao.</p> <p>Again there are those whose only care is phraseology.</p> <p>The brilliancy of the Tao is an obscurity; the advance of the Tao is a</p> | <p>When the superiour scholar is told of Tao,</p> <p>He works hard to practise it.</p> <p>When the middling scholar is told of Tao,</p> <p>It seems that sometimes he keeps it and sometimes he loses it.</p> <p>When the inferiour scholar is told of Tao,</p> <p>He laughs aloud at it.</p> <p>If it were not laughed at, it would not be sufficient to be Tao.</p> <p>Therefore the proverb says:</p> <p>'Tao in enlightenment seems obscure;</p> <p>Tao in</p> | <p>Playing with Reversal</p> <p>The 'superior' scholar hears a guide.</p> <p>He gets all serious and follows it.</p> <p>The 'medium' scholar hears a guide.</p> <p>It's like it endures; it's like it disappears!</p> <p>The 'lower' scholar hears a guide.</p> <p>He hilariously laughs at it.</p> <p>If he did not laugh, it would not be up to being deemed a guide.</p> <p>Hence, as the saying goes--</p> <p>A discerning guide is like a murky one.</p> <p>An guide to advancing is like one to</p> |
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## Chapter 42

From out of the Cosmic  
Consciousness

Arose the One.

Then from the One came  
Two.

And from Two came Three.

From the great Three came  
The endless compressions of  
Being.

Each compressed form bears  
yin behind

And holds yang before it.

At the still point in the center

These complementary  
energies merge,

And harmony is thus  
realized.

Why does hatred fill the  
hearts of men

At the sight of poverty and  
solitude,

When the greatest leaders  
make these their name?

Perhaps increase and loss

Out of Tao comes  
Unity; out of Unity  
comes two;  
from two comes  
three; from three all  
things come.

The shade of Yin is  
on the back of  
everything;  
the light of Yang is  
on the face of  
everything.

From their blending  
together  
balance

The Tao produced the One. The One produced two; the two produced three; the three produced all things.

Everything is permeated by the yin and the yang and vivified by the immaterial breath.

That which men hate is to be kithless, friendless and considered unworthy, but princes and dukes thus style themselves.

Tao begets one; one  
begets two; two  
begets three; three  
begets all things.

Generating Things  
A guide generates 'one.'  
'One' generates 'two.'  
'Two' generates 'three.'  
'Three' generates the ten-thousand natural kinds.  
The ten-thousand natural kinds bear Yin and embrace Yang.  
Blend the life-forces and deem-make 'harmony.'  
What humans revile is specifically 'orphan,' 'lonely' and 'impoverished.'

---

exists in the world.  
To feel unworthy, to  
be alone, orphaned,  
is greatly feared and  
disliked,  
yet statesmen claim  
these feelings.  
Loss sometimes  
benefits; benefits can  
be a loss.  
Others have taught  
this too:  
the violent meet  
violent ends.  
This is a good  
teaching.

Form this it would appear that advantages are disadvantageous, and disadvantages are advantageous.

I teach what others have taught.

The violent and the fierce do no live out their years.

I shall be chief among the teachers.

All things are backed by the Shade, (yin) and faced by the light (yang), and harmonised by the immaterial Breath (ch'i).

What others teach, I also teach: 'The daring and violent do not die a natural death.' This (maxim) I shall regard as my instructor.

deem them as titles.

Hence among natural kinds: sometimes you diminish it and it increases.

Sometime you increase it and it diminishes.

What humans teach, I also teach.

Those who force issues don't get their death.

I'm on the point of deeming this 'the father of teaching.'

Within the realm of Nature,  
The gentle horse runs free,  
While more intransigent  
forms stay fixed.  
Non-being is able to infiltrate  
Where there isn't any room.  
Thus I see that unforced  
action  
Is the only path to success,  
And that the greatest  
eloquence is silence.  
Action free of noise and  
expectation:  
This is Nature's teaching,  
Which but few have truly  
learned.  
Listen to your own true  
nature,  
And learn.

The softest will  
penetrate the hardest.

The non-existent will  
penetrate the  
existent.

By this I know the  
value

The world's weakest  
drives the world's  
strongest.

The indiscernible  
penetrates where  
there are no crevices.

From this I perceive

The non-existent can enter into the impenetrable.

By this I know that non-action is

Absolute Negation

The most yielding in the social world gallops over the most firm in the social world.

That which lacks being enters into that which lacks space.

I,

\_\_\_\_\_

of being passive.  
This is teaching  
without words,  
achievement without  
direct action.  
In all the world few  
know this.

the advantage of non-action.

Few indeed in the world realize the instruction of the silence, or the benefits of inaction.

useful.

Teaching without  
words, utility without  
action-

Few in the world  
have come to this.

with this, know the advantage of lacking deem-acting.

The teaching that is not put in language,

The advantage of lacking deem-acting,

In the social world, these are rarely achieved.

|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |                                                                                                                                                               |                                                                                                                                                    |                                                                                                                                                                                                         |                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
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| <p>A great name or self-knowledge:</p> <p>To which of these does your heart respond?</p> <p>Material goods or your natural virtues:</p> <p>Which do you treasure more?</p> <p>Profit or loss: which is more apt</p> <p>To lead you toward destruction?</p> <p>The love of excess lays Nature waste:</p> <p>It spends the self and buys remorse.</p> <p>Accumulation is the greatest loss.</p> <p>Meet your needs and go no further,</p> <p>And you will be a stranger to disgrace.</p> <p>Recognize the limits of every situation,</p> <p>And you'll be free from danger.</p> | <p>Fame or self: which is more important?</p> <p>Wealth or self: which is more valuable?</p> <p>Gain or loss: which is the greater evil?</p> <p>Overdoing</p> | <p>Fame or life, which is dearer? Life or wealth, which is more? Gain or loss, which is worse?</p> <p>Excessive love implies excessive outlay.</p> | <p>Fame or your person, which is nearer to you?</p> <p>Your person or wealth, which is dearer to you?</p> <p>Gain or loss, which brings more evil to you?</p> <p>Over-love of anything will lead to</p> | <p>Moderate Values</p> <p>Your name or your self--which is closest to you?</p> <p>Your self and commodities--which counts as more?</p> <p>Obtaining and losing--which is a defect?</p> <p>For this reason,</p> |
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## Chad Hansen

Extremes and  
Reversals

Great completion is  
like deficiency.

Its use does not  
'corrupt'.

Great filling is like  
being poured.

Its use does not  
exhaust.

Great  
straightforwardness  
is like being

bent.

Great skill is like  
clumsiness.

Great  
distinction-debating  
is like shouting.

Exercise conquers a  
chill.

Rest conquers a  
fever.

'Clear' and 'quiet' are  
deemed as correct for  
the social world.

When the Tao suffuses man and Nature,  
Swift horses nourish the fields with their dung.  
When people abandon the Tao,  
The horses are bred for battle,  
And Nature is defiled.  
The greatest disaster is to lack contentment.  
The greatest curse is wanting more than you need.  
Therefore the student of the Sage  
Feels exactly when he has enough,  
And thus receives eternal contentment.

**Contentment**  
When the world follows Tao,  
racehorses work on farms.  
When the world forsakes Tao,  
cavalry horses practice in parks.  
The greatest

When the empire is controlled by the Tao, riding horses are employed in agriculture; when the empire is without Tao, war horses are in every open space.

Swift horses are curbed for hauling dung-carts (in the field).  
When Tao does not reign in the world,  
War horses are bred on the commons (outside the cities)  
There is no greater crime

**Guiding Contentment**  
When the social world has a guide  
We turn back fast horses in order to fertilize.  
When the social world lacks a guide  
War horses are produced in

When horses are free to run (remember the discussion of wu-wei in Chapter 43), they spread nourishment back to the earth as fertilizer.  
But when they are bred and trained for war, then their nourishing dung is wasted on the killing fields, which are poisoned with the blood of human slaughter.

curse is discontent.  
It is the greatest misery.  
The greatest sin is selfish striving.  
Being content with contentment  
is to be always satisfied.

There is no sin greater than covetousness; no calamity greater than discontent; no fault greater than acquisitiveness.  
Who therefore knows the contentment of content possesses unchanging content.

than seeking what men desire;  
There is no greater misery than knowing no content;  
There is no greater calamity than indulging in greed.  
Therefore the contentment of knowing content will ever be contented.

the suburbs.  
Among bad omens, none is greater than not knowing to 'sufficient.'  
Among evils, none is greater than desiring 'getting.'  
Hence, knowing to 'sufficient' is sufficient  
for constant sufficiency.

## Chapter 47

Without leaving home,  
You can learn the Way of Nature.

Without opening your eyes,  
You can walk the path of truth.

The farther you wander without,  
The more you separate from realization.

Thus the student of the Sage:  
He never starts an outward journey  
Before there is clarity within.

He analyzes nothing,  
Yet finds words for everything.

He does not strive,  
Yet his work is brought to completion.

This poem is one of many teachings on meditation in the Tao Te Ching. —

One can know the world without leaving the house.  
One can see Tao without looking out the window.  
The

The world may be known without going out of doors.

The heavenly way (Tao) may be seen without looking through the

Without going out of  
the door  
One can know the  
whole world;  
Without peeping out  
of the window  
One can see the Tao  
of heaven.  
The

Ignorant Guides.

Don't step outside your door. Know the social world.

Don't look out the window. See the natural guide.

The farther you go the less you

A vertical axis with 20 horizontal tick marks, evenly spaced, extending from the bottom to the top of the page.

more you study the  
less you know.  
Thus the truly wise  
know without  
traveling,  
perceive without  
seeing, achieve  
without doing.

window.  
 The further one goes  
 the less one knows.  
 Hence the Holy Man  
 arrives without  
 traveling; names  
 without looking;  
 accomplishes without  
 action.

further one travels  
The less one knows.  
Therefore the Sage  
knows everything  
without travelling;  
He names everything  
without seeing it;  
He accomplishes  
everything without  
doing it.

know what to do.

Using this: Sages  
don't go anywhere  
and yet know what to  
do.

Don't see and yet  
name things.

Don't deem-act and  
yet accomplish.

Pursuing knowledge: daily accumulation.

Following Tao: daily unburdening.

Decrease, diminish, deprogram:

Continue in this till power is dead.

For when action lacks force,

Nothing is left unaccomplished.

Rely upon your true eternal nature,

And you will never have to strive again.

But let your life become

A game of inner commerce,

And you will never cease with making deals;

You will never feel fulfilled-

In this or any other world.

The scholar needs to know more and more each day.

The follower of Tao needs to know less and less each day.

By lessening knowledge one reaches inaction.

The pursuit of study  
bring daily increase;  
the pursuit of Tao  
brings daily decrease;  
decrease upon  
decrease, until  
non-action is  
reached,

He who pursues  
learning will increase  
every day;  
He who pursues Tao  
will decrease every  
day.  
He

Forgetting

In deem-acting on 'study' one daily increases.

In deem-acting on 'the guide ' one daily decreases.

Decrease it and further decrease it.

In order to arrive at no deem-acting.

No deem-acting and

---

By inaction  
everything can be  
done.

The world is won by  
those who leave it  
alone.

When one feels  
compelled to  
dominate,  
the world is already  
beyond reach.

whence all action proceeds.

Only continued non-concern will win the Empire; where there is concern there is an insufficiency for the task.

will decrease and  
continue to decrease,  
Till he comes to  
non-action;  
By non-action  
everything can be  
done.

nothing not  
deem-acted.

Taking the social  
world , you treat  
relying on lacking  
social acts as  
constant.

When it comes to  
engaging in social  
acts,

it is not sufficient for  
taking the social  
world.



# Chapter 49

Brian Donohue

C. Ganson

C. Spurgeon Medhurst

Ch'u Ta-Kao

Chad Hansen

|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
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| <p>The Sage is free of the law of fixed belief;</p> <p>It reflects the heart of every seeker.</p> <p>Where sincerity is revealed,</p> <p>The Sage responds in kind.</p> <p>Where one's true self is repressed,</p> <p>The Sage remains sincere.</p> <p>Loyally approach the Sage,</p> <p>And your loyalty will be returned.</p> <p>Doubtfully approach the Sage,</p> <p>And your doubt will be returned</p> <p>In truthful Modesty.</p> <p>The nature of the Sage dwells in humility;</p> <p>In humility may it be experienced.</p> <p>Humility is the breath of the Cosmos.</p> | <p>The truly wise are selfless.</p> <p>People's needs are their needs.</p> <p>The good are treated with goodness;</p> <p>the bad are also treated with goodness;</p> <p>this is the goodness of Teh.</p> <p>The faithful are treated with faith;</p> <p>the</p> | <p>The Holy Man is not inflexible, he plans according to the needs of the people.</p> <p>I would return good for good. I would also return good for evil. Thus goodness operates (or "thus all become good").</p> <p>I would return trust for trust.</p> | <p>The Sage has no self to call his own.</p> <p>He makes the self of the people his self.</p> <p>To the good I act with goodness;</p> <p>To the bad I also act with godness:</p> <p>Thus goodness is attained.</p> <p>To the faithful I act with faith;</p> <p>To the</p> | <p>Sage's Constancy</p> <p>Sages lack a constant heart-mind;</p> <p>they deem the public's heart-mind as heart-mind.</p> <p>Things which are worthy, I 'worthy'.</p> <p>Things which are unworthy, I also 'worthy'</p> <p>This treats 'worthy'-ing as a virtuosity.</p> <p>Things which are reliable, I</p> |
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| <p>Into life they arise,<br/>Through death they return.<br/>A third of them seem bound up with their lives;<br/>A third of them seem attached to death;<br/>Another third appear ambivalent-<br/>Passively shifting their allegiance<br/>From each to each.<br/>Why is this so?<br/>Perhaps from an obsessive attachment<br/>To life's mere appearance?<br/>But I have heard of people<br/>Who could live long</p> | <p>Life leaves and death enters.<br/><br/>Three and ten parts accompany life;<br/>three and ten parts accompany death;<br/>three and ten parts move toward death.<br/>(Four limbs plus nine orifices.)<br/>Why? The wear of the drive to live.<br/>Why? Living tips the balance toward dying.<br/>It is said that whoever</p> | <p>Birth is an exit; death an entrance.<br/><br/>Three in ten are ways of life; three in ten are ways of death; three in ten also of those who live move into the realm of death. Why is this? Because of their excessive strivings after life. It has been said that he who thoroughly understands how to care for life will not need to shun the rhinoceros or the tiger; he need not fear weapons even in the midst of battle.</p> | <p>Men go out of life and enter into death.<br/><br/>The parts (proportions) of life are three in ten, the parts of death are also three in ten. Men that from birth move towards the region of death are also three in ten. Why is it so? Because of their redundant effort in seeking to live. But only those who do nothing for the purpose of living are better than those who prize their lives.</p> | <p>Fantasies of Avoiding Death<br/><br/>We emerge into life and enter into death.<br/><br/>Of life's associates, ten have three.<br/>Of death's associates, ten have three.<br/><br/>People's being alive, death ground's activities<br/>also ten have three.<br/><br/>Now, why is this?<br/><br/>Because they 'life' the thickness of life.<br/><br/>In general, when we hear about those worthy to abet</p> |
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| <p>and travel far-<br/>Ever free of harm or mortal wound<br/>From wild beasts or deadly weapons.<br/>A rhinoceros would find no place to pierce them;<br/>There would be no meat for a tiger's claws,<br/>And no place where a sword could enter.<br/>And why is this so?<br/>Because they have shed the illusion<br/>That marks off life<br/>From the realm of death.</p> | <p>realizes this<br/>is not attacked by the wild buffalo or tiger<br/>and is not vulnerable on the field of battle.<br/>The buffalo's horns find no place to gore,<br/>the tiger's claws no place to tear,<br/>the soldier's weapons no place to pierce.<br/>Why? Because death is not yet within reach.</p> | <p>The rhinoceros finds no place into which to thrust his horn; the tiger no place into which to fix his claws; nor the sword a place into which to flesh its point. Why is this?<br/>Because such a one is not moved by the thought of death.</p> | <p>For I have heard that he who knows well how to conserve life, when travelling on land, does not meet the rhinoceros or the tiger; when going to a battle, he is not attacked by arms and weapons. The rhinoceros can find nowhere to drive his horn; the tiger can find nowhere to put his claws; the weapons can find nowhere to thrust their blades. Why is it so? Because he is far beyond the region of death.</p> | <p>life:<br/>They walk the earth without encountering rhinoceros or tiger.<br/><br/>They enter the army and don't bear armor or weapons.<br/><br/>The rhinoceros has no place to thrust its horn.<br/><br/>The tiger has no place to wield its claws.<br/><br/>Arms have no place to accommodate their points.<br/><br/>Now, why is this?<br/><br/>Because they lack death's ground.</p> |
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| <p>Life: the gift of Tao.</p> <p>Growth: the gift of Te.</p> <p>Form and matter merge;</p> <p>Beings are brought to maturity,</p> <p>Each in its unique nature.</p> <p>Everything within Nature</p> <p>Lives for Tao and loves Te.</p> <p>It is a love of attraction,</p> <p>And not of constraint.</p> <p>Love forever free of expectation</p> <p>Is the love that has always been.</p> <p>For life is the gift of Tao,</p> <p>And growth, the gift of Te.</p> <p>As One, they nourish and nurture;</p> <p>They bring maturity and completion;</p> <p>They protect, provide, and teach</p> | <p>Tao causes all things to exist; Teh sustains them.</p> <p>Reality gives them form; fate completes them.</p> <p>Thus all things honor Tao and respect Teh of their own accord.</p> <p>Teh sustains all things in existence.</p> <p>It fosters</p> | <p>Whet the Tao produces and its energy nourishes, nature forms and natural forces establish. On this account there is nothing that does not honour the Tao and reverence its energy. This honour and reverence are spontaneous, not the result of a mandate.</p> <p>So the Tao produces.</p> | <p>Tao produces them (all things);</p> <p>Virtue feeds them;</p> <p>All of them appear in different forms;</p> <p>Each is perfect by being given power.</p> <p>Therefore none of the numerous things does not honour Tao and esteem virtue.</p> <p>The honouring of Tao and the esteem of virtue are done, not by command, but always of their own accord.</p> | <p>Natural Guides and Natural Virtuosity</p> <p>A guide starts it, virtuosity cultivates it, Natural kinds model it and circumstances complete it.</p> <p>For this reason, among the ten-thousand natural kinds,</p> <p>None fail to respect a guide and value virtuosity.</p> <p>This respecting of guides and valuing of virtuosity</p> <p>is not, in general, commanded in words instead</p> |
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The world as we know it has  
an origin,  
Which may be called Mother  
Formless.  
Hold the Mother to your  
deepest heart,  
And you will understand the  
Cosmic Family.  
Hold her children to your  
intuition,  
And the Mother will embrace  
you, too.  
Thus will your life flow  
freely  
Through all of your days.  
Guard the openings of speech  
and outer sensation,  
And your life will be serene.  
But if your life is spent  
In expansive oration  
And the compulsion to  
intervene,  
Your heart will be in torment  
Unto your very last breath.

The beginning of the universe  
may be considered  
the mother.

Knowing the mother  
the sons can be  
known.

Knowing the sons we  
can keep close to the  
mother.

Thus life has within  
itself security.

Eyes closed and  
mouth shut, life

Everything has its origin in the mother of all under heaven

To know the mother the child must be perceived; the child being born the qualities of the mother must be maintained, to the end of life there will be no peril.

Close the doors of the senses, and the whole of life

The beginning of the Universe, when manifested, may be regarded as its Mother.

When a man has found the Mother, he will know the children accordingly;

Though he has known the children, he still keeps to the Mother:

Thus, however his body may decay, he will never perish.

If he shuts his mouth and closes his doors, He can

So What?

The social world has a beginning

We deem it 'mother' of the social world.

Since we acquired its 'mother'

We use that to know its 'son'

Since we know its 'son'

We revert to embracing its mother.

Burying the self we risk nothing.

Shut up its exchanges

,

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is without trouble.  
Eyes open, busily  
conversant, life is  
without hope.  
Whoever sees the  
most minute sees  
clearest.  
Whoever cherishes  
the weak has the  
most strength.  
Whoever uses  
enlightenment has  
bright vision.  
Thus, no harm is  
done.  
This is following  
Tao.

will be without care;  
open them, attend to  
the affairs of life and  
to the end  
deliverance will be  
impossible.

Perceive the germ,  
that is enlightenment.

Maintain weakness,  
that is stability.

Employ the light;  
revert to this  
enlightenment; no  
calamity will then be  
bequeathed to the  
body.

This is indeed to  
practice the  
unalterable.

never be exhausted.  
If he opens his mouth  
and increases his  
affairs,  
He can never be  
saved.  
To see the  
minuteness of things  
is called clarity of  
sight.  
To keep to what is  
weak is called power.  
Use your light, but  
dim your brightness;  
Thus you will cause  
no harm to yourself.  
This is called  
following the eternal  
(Tao).

close its gates  
and end life without  
struggle.  
Open its exchanges,  
benefit its social  
affairs  
and still end life  
without saving  
anything.  
see small, say  
'discernible'  
protect weakness, say  
'coerce'  
Use its light;  
Revert and return to  
its discernment.  
Bequeath yourself no  
trouble;

Increasing evidence  
Let me suddenly  
have some  
know-how  
To exercise on The  
Great Guide--  
Only helping it--this  
I fear!  
The Great Guide is  
profoundly smooth  
and people easily  
track it.  
The palace is  
profoundly

stripped.

Fields are profoundly overgrown.

Granaries are profoundly bare.

Clothes embroidered colorfully.

Belts have sharp swords.

Bored of drink and food.

Wealth and commodities are excessive.

This is called 'stealing.'

Exaggeration!

Not a guide!

With a firm inner foundation,  
You cannot be toppled.  
An embrace is all the grasp  
you need  
To be safe within.  
An offering of simple honor,  
From the children of the past  
To the children of the present  
Supports the children of the  
future.  
Why do you cultivate your  
image  
When your natural being is  
already full?  
Why aggrandize your family  
pride  
When the perfection of  
family is complete?  
Why meddle with your  
community  
When its natural form is  
imperishable?  
Why do

Whatever is firmly  
planted is not easily  
uprooted.  
Whatever is firmly  
grasped is not easily  
loosened.  
Generation follows  
generation,  
continuing endlessly.  
Accept Tao in  
yourself and Teh is  
yours.  
Accept Tao in the  
family and Teh is  
abundant.  
Accept Tao in the  
village and Teh  
multiplies.  
Accept Tao in the  
nation and Teh

Who plants well will  
not have his work  
uprooted; who  
embraces well will  
not lose what he  
holds; the offerings  
of his sons and  
grandsons will never  
end.  
Who thus regulates  
himself has virtue  
which is genuine;  
who thus regulates  
his household has  
virtue which  
overflows; who thus  
regulates his  
neighbourhood has  
virtue which excels;  
who thus regulates

What is planted by the  
best planter can never  
be removed;  
What is embraced by  
the best embracer can  
never be loosened.  
Thus his children and  
grandchildren will be  
able to continue their  
ancestral sacrifice for  
endless generations.  
If he applies Tao to  
himself his virtue will  
be genuine;  
If he applies it to his  
family his virtue will  
be abundant;  
If he applies it to his  
village his virtue will  
be lasting;  
If

Culturing  
Perspectives  
Worthy builders do  
not tear down.  
Worthy embracers do  
not let go.  
Sons and grandsons  
never stop  
sacrificing.  
Culture it in one self  
and its virtuosity is  
authenticity.  
Culture it in a family  
and its virtuosity is  
sufficiency.  
Culture it in a village  
and its virtuosity is  
elders.  
Culture it in a state

you fight to enrich your  
nation  
When its simple order is  
abundance?  
Why divide and oppose earth  
and heaven  
When the purity of their  
union is unalterable?  
Therefore, examine yourself  
To become your Self.  
Examine your home  
To become a family.  
Examine your village  
To become a community.  
Examine the state  
To become a nation.  
Examine the world  
To become one with Being.  
How do I know  
That this is the way of  
Nature?  
Because I asked It,

flourishes.  
Accept Tao in the  
world and Teh is  
universal.  
Therefore, one can  
measure by Teh:  
By your Teh gauge  
the family.  
By the family's Teh  
gauge the village.  
By the village's Teh  
gauge the nation.  
By the nation's Teh  
gauge the world.  
How do I know this  
is so? By seeing it so!

the state has virtue  
which abounds; who  
thus regulates the  
world has virtue  
which is universal.  
Therefore let every  
man prove himself;  
let each household,  
neighbourhood, and  
state do the same; let  
the world also follow  
the same course.  
How do I know that  
it must be thus with  
the world? By this  
same (which has just  
been said).

he applies it to his  
country his virtue will  
be full;  
If he applies it to the  
world his virtue will  
be universal.  
Therefore by one's  
person one may  
observe persons;  
By one's family one  
may observe families;  
By one's village one  
may observe villages;  
By one's country one  
may observe  
countries;  
By one's world, one  
may observe worlds.  
How do I know that  
the world may be so  
(governed by Tao)?

and its virtuosity is  
wealth.  
Culture it in the  
social world  
and its virtuosity is  
universality.  
Hence use 'self' to  
view the self.  
'Family' to view the  
family.  
'Village' to view the  
village.  
'State' to view the  
state.  
'Social world' to view  
the social world.  
How do I know the  
social world's  
condition?  
With this.

## Chapter 55

One whose inner strength is  
full and clear

Seems like one who's just  
arrived

From another world.

To him, the bee has no sting,  
The serpent, no venom.

To him, the wild beasts  
Have no teeth or claws.

To him, predatory birds  
Present no menace.

His skeleton seems weak,  
His muscles tender,

Yet he's got a grip like a vise.

He appears to lack experience

In the dance of sexual  
relations-

Yet his genitals are fully  
formed,

And he knows how to use  
them.

People yell every day,

Whoever has Teh is like a child:  
Poisonous insects will not bit.  
Wild animals will not attack.  
Predatory birds will not strike.  
Bones soft, muscles weak, but gripping strongly.  
Unconcerned about sex yet most vigorous.  
Crying out all day long but not hoarse.  
This involves perfect harmony.

Who cherishes energy in abundance is comparable to a child. Poisonous insects will not sting him; fierce beasts will not seize him; birds of prey will not strike him.

His bones are weak; his sinews pliable; his grip firm; unconscious of sex, his virility is active – the excellency of his physique.

He who is endowed  
with ample virtue  
may be compared to  
an infant.

No venomous insects  
sting him;

Nor fierce beasts  
seize him;

Nor birds of prey  
strike him;

His bones are frail,  
his sinews tender, but  
his grasp is strong.

He does not know the  
conjugation of male  
and female, and yet  
he has sexual  
development;

It

Abstruse Signs

The thickness of implicit virtuosity:

Compare it to a robust infant.

Bees, scorpions, serpents, and snakes do not sting.

Ferocious animals do not seize.

Birds of prey do not take.

Bones are weak and muscles soft and yet he has a firm grasp.

He does not yet know to join male and female and yet he is completely ready.

This is the instinct's having

Knowing harmony is  
to approach the  
eternal.

Knowing the eternal  
is to be enlightened.

To become excitable  
leads to confusion.

To freely vent  
emotions is to be  
aggressive.

Things reach their  
prime and then  
decline.

To be impatient is to  
oppose Tao.

Whatever opposes  
Tao dies young.

He may cry all day without become hoarse – this is the consummation of harmony.

Knowledge of harmony is called "The unalterable;" knowledge of the Unalterable is called "Illumination."

Increase of life is called infelicity, the resting of the mind in the vitality of forms is called animality.

The corporeal begins to age as it nears its prime. This indeed is not the Tao. What is not the Tao soon ends.

means he is in the best vitality.

He may cry all day without growing hoarse;

It means that he is in the perfect harmony.

To know this harmony is to approach eternity.

To know eternity is to attain enlightenment.

To increase life is to lead to calamity.

To let the heart exert the breath is to become stark.

arrived.

The whole day he  
babbles and he does not  
get hoarse.

This is the balance  
having arrived.

Knowing to balance,  
call it 'constant'

Knowing how to stay  
constant, call it  
'discernment.'

Benefiting life, call it  
'auspicious.'

The heart-mind's  
deploying life-force,  
call it 'coercion.'

When natural kinds are  
mature then old age  
sets in.

Call this not guided.

That which is not  
guided is early already.

## Chapter 56

Understanding doesn't talk a lot;

A lot of talk lacks understanding.

Can you be guided by silence?

Can you shut down your outer senses?

Can you blunt your jagged edges?

Can you let the inner knots unravel?

Can you let your brilliance be dimmed?

Can you merge with the dust of the earth?

This is called "harmonizing light and dark."

In this, you possess no one,  
But are loved by many.

You are equally immune  
To attraction and revulsion.

You are equally receptive  
To profit and to loss.

Whoever knows does  
not speak;  
whoever speaks does  
not know.

So, stop the senses.  
Close their doors.  
Solve their riddles.  
Subdue their light.

Be one with humble  
dust.

This

Who knows does not speak; who speaks does not know.

Close the doors of the senses; blunt the sharp; unravel the confused; harmonize the dazzling; become one with the all.

Blunt all that is sharp;  
Cut all that is divisible;  
Blur all that which is brilliant;  
Mix with all that is humble as dust;  
This is called absolute equality.  
Therefore it cannot be made

Abstruse Virtuosity  
Those who know to  
act do not speak.  
Those who speak, do  
not know to act.  
Shut up its  
exchanges,  
close its gates.  
Dull its sharpness,  
undo its divisions.  
Balance its  
brightness,  
treat its particles as  
identical.  
This

A vertical axis with 20 horizontal tick marks, evenly spaced, for plotting data.

is the mystic unity.  
It is beyond love and  
hate,  
beyond profit and  
loss,  
beyond honor and  
dishonor.  
Thus it is the most  
valuable treasure  
in all the world.

This is the Mystery of Unity. There will then neither be love nor hate; profit not loss; favour or disgrace. It follows that in the universe there is nothing nobler.

intimate;  
Nor can it be  
alienated.  
It cannot be  
benefited;  
Nor can it be harmed.  
It cannot be exalted;  
Nor can it be  
debased.  
Therefore it is the  
most valuable thing  
in the world.

is called the abstruse identity.

Hence we cannot obtain and be close.

Cannot obtain and be distant.

Cannot obtain and benefit.

Cannot obtain and harm.

Cannot obtain and value.

Cannot obtain and debase.

Hence we deem the social world as valuable.



In government, objectives are clarified.

In warfare, objectives are concealed.

In following the Tao, objectives are discarded.

How do I know that this is so?

By feeling it from within.

With every commandment thrust upon the people,

They become more impoverished and alienated.

As the weapons of the state grow ever more destructive,

The more contagious is the fear that desolates the nation.

The further science spreads its hegemony of the intellect,

The more demonic are the products that roll off the assembly line.

As the precedents of litigation grow, and the statutory codes accumulate,

Be Lawful, Not Full of Laws

Rule by what is right.

Wage war by clever strategy.

Win the world by being passive.

How do I know? By this:

More restrictions mean weaker people.

More weapons mean a troubled state.

More cunning

Rule the Empire with uprightness. The Empire is won by non-concern. How do I know this? Thus: The more superstitious restrictions in the land the poorer the people; the more the people are concerned with the administration the more benighted the state and the clans; the more craftiness is displayed the greater the

number of novelties which arise.

Albeit one governs the country by rectitude,

And carries on wars by stratagems,

Yet one must rule the empire by meddling with no business.

The empire can always be ruled by meddling with no business.

Otherwise, it can never be done.

How do I know this is so?

By this:

The more restrictions and avoidances are in the empire,

The poorer become the people;

The more sharp implements the people keep,

The more confusions are in the country;

The

Laissez Faire Politics

Use correcting to order the state.

Use shock in deploying military force.

Use absence of social matters to take charge of the social world.

How do I know these are so?

With this.

The more the social world has to elude,

the more the people are impoverished.

The more the people have beneficial artifacts,

the more the state and society are befuddled.

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means many surprises.

More laws mean more violators.

Be passive and the people will be reformed.

Be serene and the people will be righteous.

Be peaceable and the people will be wealthy.

Be selfless and the people will be simple and serene.

The more legislation there is the more thieves and robbers increase.

It is for these reasons that a sage has said: "I do nothing, but the people spontaneously reform. I love tranquility, and the people spontaneously become upright. I have no concerns, and the people naturally grow wealthy. I am without desire, and of their own free will the people revert to primitive simplicity."

more arts and crafts men have,

The more are fantastic things produced;

The more laws and regulations are given,

The more robbers and thieves there are.

Therefore the Sage says;

Inasmuch as I betake myself to non-action, the people of themselves become developed.

Inasmuch as I love quietude, the people of themselves become righteous.

Inasmuch as I make no fuss, the people of themselves become wealthy.

Inasmuch as I am free from desire, the people of themselves remain simple.

The more humans are skilled and clever

the more strange natural kinds crop up.

The more standards of behavior and commands are promulgated,

the more thieves and robbers there are.

Hence sages say:

I lack deeming-action and the people self-transform.

I remain calm and the people self-correct.

I avoid social matters and the people self-enrich.

When the government lacks power and brilliance,  
Organic simplicity suffuses the people.

When the government is intrusive and vigilant,  
Deceit and resentment are the coin of the realm.

Misfortune enters the life  
That is propped up on success,  
And misery lurks beneath  
The lustrous show of affluence.

Life that lacks limits lacks duration.  
If it is elevated today,  
It will be tomorrow maligned.

When everything is changing,  
Nothing is transformed.

Insight is caked with the ink of the prophets.

To Govern, Be Gentle

Govern passively, the people are happy.

Govern precisely, the people are restless.

Happiness arises from unhappiness; unhappiness lies beneath happiness.

Who knows what is best?

When the state is self-righteous, self-righteousness

When the government is not in evidence the people are honest and loyal.

When the government is meddlesome the people are in want.

Misery! Happiness lies by its side!

Happiness! Misery lurks underneath. He who understands the end has progressed beyond limitations.

The regular becomes irregular; the good becomes unpropitious.

When the government is blunt and inactive the people will be happy and prosperous;

When the government is discriminative, the people will be dissatisfied and restless.

It is upon misery that happiness rests;

It is under happiness that misery lies.

Who then can know the supremacy (good government)?

Only when the government does no

Political Reversal  
Its regime is torpid  
its people are  
guileless.  
Its government is  
critically  
discriminating  
its people are  
deficient.  
Calamity! The  
ground of fortuity.  
Fortuity! The  
obverse of calamity.  
Who knows its  
pivot?  
It lacks a 'correct'  
The 'correct'

---

becomes strategy  
and good becomes  
evil.

Man has long been  
misguided.

The truly wise are:  
square  
(sharp-cornered) but  
not cutting;  
angled (wedge-like)  
but not interfering;  
straight (pointed) but  
not domineering;  
bright (enlightened)  
but not binding.

This has bewildered men from time immemorial!

Hence the Holy Man is a square which has not been cut, and whose corners have not been planed; he is straightforward without being reckless, and bright without being dazzling.

rectifying.  
Otherwise the  
rectitude will again  
become stratagem,  
And good beome  
evil.  
Men have been  
ignorant of this, since  
long ago.  
Therefore the Sage is  
square but does not  
cut others;  
He is angled but does  
not chip others;  
He is straight but  
does not stretch  
others;  
His is bright but does  
not dazzle others.

returns to be deemed  
unorthodox.

Worthiness returns to  
be deemed an  
apparition.

Human superstition  
a truly old story.

Using this: Sages  
square things without  
carving

Are fair without  
punishing.

Are straight without  
being arbitrary.

Are bright without  
dazzling us.

In helping others, be like the sky:

Without the slightest sense of sacrifice,

It readily yields the elements

That make the harvest possible.

Reflecting nurturance is called

Continual nourishment of the harvest.

Continual nourishment arises from Modesty,

Which is the most bountiful harvest of all.

Modesty in abundance is indomitable-

It is indomitable, so who could know

The limits of its capacity?

And if its limits cannot be known,

Couldn't it nurture an entire nation?

**With Tao, You Are Supreme**

In ruling men be reserved.

To be reserved is to conform to Tao.

To conform to Tao is to achieve Teh.

With Teh anything is possible.

Because anything is possible,

no

For the regulation of mankind and the service of heaven nothing equals reserve power. Reserve power means a speedy submission. Speedy submission implies a rich store of energy. A rich store of energy means the subjugation of everything. Everything being subdued none knows his limits.

In ruling men and in serving heaven, the Sage uses only moderation.

By moderation alone he is able to have conformed early (to Tao).

This early conformity is called intensive accumulation of virtue.

With this intensive accumulation of virtue, there is nothing that he cannot overcome.

Because there is nothing that he cannot overcome, no one

**A Sensible Guide**

In governing people and serving nature, nothing is better than conserving.

In general, only conserving

deserves to be called early readiness.

Early readiness: call it emphasizing accumulating virtuosity.

If one emphasizes accumulating virtuosity then there is nothing one cannot conquer.

If there is

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one knows your supremacy.

Because no one knows your supremacy,

a nation can be ruled well.

Because this is a Mother Principle

it long endures.

Therefore you are as deeply rooted

and as immortal as it is.

His limits being unknown his sovereign power is assured, having the root of sovereignty which endures for long.

This may be described as a "deep taproot," and a "durable peduncle," – the perpetual vitality and continued manifestation of the Tao.

will be able to know his supremacy.

Because no one knows his supremacy he can take possession of a country.

Because what he does is identified with the Mother in taking possession of a country, he can long endure.

This means that he is deep rooted and firmly based, and knows the way of longevity and immortality.

nothing one cannot conquer, no one knows one's limit.

Those of whom no one knows their limits

may take states.

The mother of taking states

is able to endure.

This is called the deep root and inherent base

Of the guide to long-life and enduring vision.

Skill at Ruling  
Ruling a large state  
Is like grilling a  
small bit of fresh  
food.  
Using a guide to  
manage the social  
world  
Its ghost does not  
energize.  
If it is not that its  
ghost does not  
energize,

Its energy does not harm humans.

If it is not that its energy does not harm humanity,

Sages also do not harm humans.

In general, when both of these do not mutually harm,

Then virtuosity exchanges and returns in it.

How does a great nation know its neighbors?

As a river modestly accepts its feeding streams;

As a woman blissfully receives the man she loves.

The way of Nature is attraction:

Pure strength rests below,

And thus absorbs what lies above.

Genuine love receives its complement;

The greatest nation yields.

Small and great are mutually fulfilling:

Set them into opposition,

And you have made your first and final error.

Therefore, let your nation follow Nature's way:

If it is big, let its actions be small.

If it is small, it is already complete,

The Tao of Statecraft

A great nation is one to which the streams descend.

It is the meeting place, the female of the world.

Quiet, passive, leading the male by humble submission.

A great nation lowers itself to the smaller

and thus wins the smaller nation.

A smaller nation lowers

A great country is lowly. Everything under heaven blends with it. It is like the female, which at all times and in every place overcomes the male by her quietude. Than quietude there is nothing that is more lowly.

Therefore a great state gains the smaller state by yielding; while the smaller state wins the greater by submission.

A great state is the world's low-stream (to which all the river flows [sic] down), the world's field and the world's female. The female always conquers the male by quietude, which is employed as a means to lower oneself. Thus a great state lowers itself towards a small state before it takes over the small state.

Virtuosity at Using 'Beneath'

Those which are great states flow downward.

The interchanges in the social world!

The female of the social world!

The female constants using stillness. She conquer the male using stillness to act out 'beneath'.

Hence if great states use 'beneath' on small states,

then they take small states.

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itself beneath the greater

and thus wins the greater nation.

So, some lower themselves to win others;

some are already low, and therefore win others.

A great nation wants more people;

a small nation wants more room.

When both are dedicated to these ends,

the greater nation should humbly yield.

In the one case lowliness gains adherents, in the other it procures favours.

For a strong state there is no safer ambition than to desire to gather men and care from them; and for the weaker state there is nothing better than the ambition to become an indispensable servant.

When each obtains what each desires the strongest should be the humblest.

A small state lowers itself towards a great state before it takes over the great state. Therefore some lower themselves to take, while some lower themselves to gather. A great state wishes nothing more than to have and keep many people, and a small state wishes nothing more than to get more things to do. When the two both mean to obtain their wishes, the greater one should lower itself.

If small states use 'beneath' on great states,

then they take great states.

Hence some 'beneath' in order to take,

some 'beneath' and then take.

Great states simply desire universally domesticating people.

Small states simply desire serving people.

So of the two, each gets what it wants.

The great fittingly deems 'beneath'.

## Chapter 62

Tao is the treasure of all being.  
Those who accord with it  
Are embraced by it.  
And for those who wander,  
Its arms remain open.  
Eloquence may fetch its price,  
Heroic deeds may garner glory,  
But only at the brutal cost  
Of a person's deepest self.  
Is fame worth such a sacrifice?  
What if you were called to command  
At the coronation of a king-  
If the three imperial generals  
Marched in state before you  
Leading out majestic stallions,  
To confer on you the jade emblem

Tao is at the source  
of everything:  
treasure for the good,  
refuge for the bad.  
Fine words can be  
sold;  
fine deeds can be just  
a show.  
Why then reject the  
bad?  
Therefore, at the  
crowning of the  
emperor  
or at the appointment  
of the three

The Tao has of all things the most honoured place.

It is the good man's treasure, and that which protects the bad man.

Its excellent words may be displayed before all. Its noble deeds assist all men.

Why should a man be cast aside because he is bad?

Hence when the sovereign has been enthroned, and the chief ministers have been appointed, though one escorted by a

Tao is the source of all things, the treasure of good men, and the sustainer of bad men.

Therefore at the enthronement of an emperor and the appointment of the three ministers, better still than those who present jewels followed by horses, is the one who sitting presents (propounds) this Tao.

Construing a Guide

A guide is a mystery among the ten-thousand natural kinds.

A treasure to worthy people.

That which non-worthy people sustain.

Beautiful language can be marketed.

Respectful behavior can augment humanness.

Those who are not worthy, what abandonment is there?

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ministers,  
rather than present  
gifts of jade and  
horses,  
present the gift of  
Tao.

Why did the ancients  
value Tao so?

Did they not say the  
seeker shall find it,  
the sinner shall find it  
and be forgiven?

So is it the treasure of  
the world.

team of horses, present the jade symbol of office, it would not equal the stilling of the heart, and entering this Tao. What is the reason that this Tao has been held in such esteem from the beginning? May we not say that is it because those who seek receive, and those who are guilty escape by its (help)? Hence it becomes the most valued things under heaven.

Why did the ancients prize this Tao? Was it not because it could be attained by seeking and thus the sinners could be freed? For this reason, it has become the most valuable thing in the world.

Good words will procure one honour; good deeds will get one credit.

dukes.

Although one presents jade followed by a team of horses

It is not as good as sitting and promoting this guide.

That which ancient times treated as valuable was guidance.

How can we not say "with seeking you get to have it, with wrongdoing avoid unorthodoxy."

Hence construe the social world's value.

Act without effort,  
Work but don't grind,  
Savor the tasteless,  
See greatness in smallness,  
And the multitude in the few.  
Answer evil with the firmest Modesty,  
Resolve difficulty at the very beginning-  
Before it becomes difficult.  
For enduring greatness is achieved  
In attending to incipient detail.  
Nature transforms complexity:  
Its greatness depends

Achieve serenity.  
Work passively.  
Taste the flavorless.  
Large or small, many or few, exchange love for hatred.  
Undertake the difficult while it is still simple.  
Undertake the great while it is still minor.  
The problems of the world must be solved while they are easy,

Practice non-action.  
Be concerned with non-concern. Taste the flavourless.  
Account the small as great, and the few as many. For hatred return perfection.  
Manipulate difficulties while they are easy. Take in hand great things while they are insignificant. Every difficult thing in the world had its origin in what was at first easy. Every great thing in the world was once significant.

Act non-action; undertake no undertaking; taste the tasteless.  
The Sage desires the desireless, and prizes no articles that are difficult to get.  
He learns no learning, but reviews what others have passed through.  
Thus he lets all things develop in their own natural way, and does not venture to act.  
Regard the small as the great; regard the few as many.  
Manage the difficult while they are easy;  
Manage the great while they are small.  
All difficult things in the world start from the easy.  
All the great

Origins in Reversal  
Treat lacking deem-action as 'deem-acting'.  
Treat having no social affair as 'social affair'.  
Treat the absence of flavor as 'flavor'.  
'Great' the small; 'many' the few;  
Use virtuosity in dealing with moral anger.  
Plan the difficult in its easy phases.  
Deem-act on the great in its small phases.

On its infinitesimal precision.  
Just so, the Cosmic Sage:  
It never strives toward greatness,  
It simply accomplishes it.  
It is not bound by promises,  
Nor moved by faith.  
In the easy is the difficult surpassed.  
The Sage treats the illness  
Before the symptoms arise.  
Thus is struggle prevented,

the great while they are minor.  
The truly wise find greatness by undertaking nothing great.  
A promise lightly made is often difficult to keep.  
Whoever makes light of things encounters many problems.  
The truly wise know that things are difficult  
and therefore meet with no difficulties.

Therefore the Holy Man makes no distinctions and thus he is able to accomplish that which is great.  
Small faith can be placed in promises lightly made.  
The easier a matter is reckoned the more difficult it proves at the last; for this reason the Holy Man sees difficulties in everything, and therefore he encounters no difficulties.

things in the world start from the small.  
The tree that fills a man's arms arises from a tender shoot.  
The nine-storied tower is raised from a heap of earth;  
A thousand miles' journey begins from the spot under one's feet.  
Therefore the Sage never attempts great things, and thus he can achieve what is great.  
He who makes easy promises will seldom keep his word;  
He who regards many things as easy will find many difficulties.  
Therefore the Sage regards things as difficult, and consequently never has difficulties.

easy.  
The great affairs of the social world start with something small.  
Using this: Sages, to the end, do not deem-act on it as 'great' and so are able to accomplish its greatness.  
In general, light assent necessarily diminishes trust.  
Much ease then necessarily much difficulty.  
Using this: Sages make it even more difficult.

## Chapter 64

Brian Donohue

C. Ganson

C. Spurgeon Medhurst

Ch'u Ta-Kao

Chad Hansen

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| <p>Affairs in balance are easily arranged.</p> <p>Trouble that's but faintly manifest</p> <p>Is resolved through preparation.</p> <p>Fragile matter is quickly broken;</p> <p>Small force is easily scattered.</p> <p>Manage trouble before others see it-</p> <p>That is, before it becomes troublesome.</p> <p>The problem that you can barely get your arms around</p> <p>Grew like a tree from the tenderest sprout.</p> <p>A tower of trouble rises from a mere hole in the ground.</p> <p>That march of agony, a thousand miles long,</p> <p>Began where your feet touch the Earth.</p> <p>Live by force and you will be destroyed by it.</p> | <p>What is not moving is easily held.</p> <p>What has not happened is easily planned.</p> <p>What is brittle is easily broken.</p> <p>What is tiny is easily dispersed.</p> <p>Deal with a problem before it arises;</p> <p>exercise control before confusion exists.</p> <p>A tree with an arm-girth of trunk grows from a tiny sprout.</p> <p>A nine-storied terrace arises from a heap of dirt.</p> <p>A thousand-mile journey begins with the first step.</p> <p>Action spoils; reaching loses.</p> | <p>Whatever is at rest can easily be taken in hand; while yet no omens have appeared plans can be easily formed.</p> <p>What is brittle is easily broken; what is minute is easily scattered.</p> <p>Act before necessity arises; regulate before disorder commences.</p> <p>The trunk that can scarcely be embraced sprang from a tiny shoot; the tower that is nine stories high was raised from a mound of earth; the journey of a thousand li commenced when the foot was placed on the ground.</p> <p>Who makes, mars; who grasps, loses.</p> <p>The —</p> | <p>What is motionless is easy to hold;</p> <p>What is not yet foreshadowed is easy to form plans for;</p> <p>What is fragile is easy to break;</p> <p>What is minute is easy to disperse.</p> <p>Deal with a thing before it comes</p> | <p>Dealing with the Small.</p> <p>It is easy to sustain a situation when it is pacified.</p> <p>It is easy to plan when it doesn't yet show signs of danger.</p> <p>It is easy to dissolve what is crisp; easy to disperse what is minute.</p> <p>Deem-act on it in its not-yet-exist phase; order it in its not-yet-disordered phase.</p> <p>An armful of wood arises from small sprouts; nine story towers start from a pile of earth.</p> <p>A thousand league walk starts with putting the foot down.</p> |
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There were those of old who  
knew the Way,  
And loved it in their daily  
lives.  
They did not preach  
enlightenment,  
Or practice deceit among the  
people.  
They lived well because they  
lived simply.  
Now with trickery and  
brilliance  
Are the people governed,  
And yet with the utmost  
difficulty!  
A country ruled with  
cleverness  
Is a country gone to waste.  
Govern your country in  
simple innocence,  
And it will be blessed among  
nations.  
Remaining aware of the  
alternatives,

Simplicity an Ancient Standard

The ancient followers of Tao

did not use it to increase knowledge, but rather to preserve simplicity.

People are difficult to govern

when there is too much knowledge.

Whoever rules a country by furthering knowledge

is that nation's curse.

Whoever rules

From the most ancient of times those who have practiced the Tao have depended on the simplicity of the people rather than on their adroitness.

When the people are difficult to control it is because they possess too much worldly wisdom.

Who governs by worldly wisdom is a robber in the land; who governs

In olden times the best practitioners of Tao did not use it to awaken people to knowledge,  
But used it to restore them to simplicity.  
People are difficult to govern because they have much knowledge.  
Therefore to govern the country by increasing the people's knowledge is to be the destroyer of the country;  
To govern

Unlearned Virtuosity

Those in ancient times who were good at deem-acting on a guide

Did not to use it to make the people discerning but to make them stupid.

People's being hard to govern comes from their knowing how to do too much.

Hence to use know-how to govern a state is the thief of the state.

Not to

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a country by  
furthering simplicity  
is that nation's  
blessing.

To know these two  
principles  
is to know the  
ancient standard.

To know the ancient  
standard  
is to possess Teh of a  
certainty.

Teh is deep and vast  
as infinity.

It returns us to primal  
peace.

without out is a blessing to the state. To know these two axioms is to become a model. To understand how to be a model is indeed the mystery of energy. Verily, deep and far-reaching is this mystery of energy. It is the opposite of all that is visible, but it leads to universal concord.

the country by decreasing knowledge is to be the blesser of the country.

To be acquainted with these two ways is to know the standard;

To keep the standard always in mind is to have sublime virtue.

Sublime virtue is infinitely deep and wide.

It goes to reverse all things;

And so it attains perfect peace.

use know-how to govern a state is the blessing of the state.

Those who know to do these two things are also evaluated models.

To treat knowing to follow evaluated models as constant,

This is called obscure virtuosity.

Obscure virtuosity becomes deep!  
Becomes distant!

Becomes the reversal of natural kinds.

After it is so, then it achieves great flow.

## Chapter 66

Breadth of river, depth of sea-  
How is it that they seem to rule the world?  
Because they can infiltrate a kingdom,  
Or plumb the depths of a ravine,  
And give life to the hundred fertile valleys.  
In leading others, learn first to follow.  
In speech, let your words find their own level.  
To lead the people, learn to nourish them.  
Let the Sage be your model:  
It dwells in leadership  
Without the oppression of superiority.  
It dwells in leadership,  
Yet the Sage offends no one.  
Thus is it honored by all who approach it,

To Lead, Appear to Follow

Why do rivers and seas have dominion over lowlands?

Because the one lowers itself to the other.

To be elevated by the people,

Speak like their inferior.

To lead the people, walk behind them.

Thus the truly

That which enables the rivers and the seas to become the rulers of all the water-courses in their ability to remain in the lowest; it is on this account that they are the rulers of them all.

As Tao is to the world, so are streams and valleys to the rivers and seas.

Rivers and seas can be kings to all valleys because the former can well lower themselves to the latter.

Thus they become kings to all valleys.

Therefore the Sage, in order to be above the people, must in words keep below them;

In order to be

**Strategic Reversal**

The reason rivers and oceans can deem-act as kings of a hundred valleys:

Is that they are good-at lowering them.

Hence they are able to deem-act as king of a hundred valleys.

Using this: if you desire to elevate the people, you must use language to diminish them.

If you desire to place the people first,

---

wise are above,  
but people do not feel  
their weight.

They walk in front,  
but people do not feel  
blocked.

The whole world  
respects  
and never grows tired  
of such leadership.

Because the truly  
wise are not  
aggressive,  
no one attacks them.

In like manner the Holy Man, if he wishes to direct the people must speak of himself as subject to them; if he wishes to lead them he must

ahead of the people,  
he must in person  
keep behind them.

Thus when he is  
above, the people do  
not feel his burden;

When he is ahead,  
the people do not feel  
his hinderance.

Therefore all the  
world is pleased to  
hold him in high  
esteem and never get  
tired of him.

Because he does not  
compete; therefore  
no one competes  
with him.

you must treat them as less than your body.

Using this: Sages occupy the upper position and the people are not important.

Occupy the prior position and the people are not harmed.

Using this: the social world happily promotes and does not resent.

It's because he does not dispute.

So in the social world, nothing disputes with him.

Three Treasures

Everyone in the social world calls my guide 'great'

It's like not resembling.

In general only being great hence like not resembling.

If it resembled, it would long since have been small!

I have three treasures. I grasp and preserve them.

The first is called 'charity' the second 'frugality' and the third not presuming to deem-act coming before the social world.

Charity, hence one can be brave.

hence one can be  
magnanimous.

Not presuming to  
deem-act coming  
before the social world,  
hence one can to fulfill  
the artifactual role of an  
elder.

Moderns abandon  
charity and are still  
brave.

Abandon frugality and  
are still liberal.

Abandon following and  
still put themselves in  
front.

Dead already!

Using charity in battle,  
one is victorious.

The natural fighter  
spurns aggression,  
For a war cannot be  
won in vengeance.  
He defeats his enemy  
by discarding enmity.  
A skillful manager  
directs the work  
By humbly serving  
those who do it.  
This is called natural  
Modesty:  
It gets things done  
without striving,  
And lets each  
individual achieve his  
destiny.  
Though the world may  
call it great,  
It is simply the  
surpassing of greatness.

Victory in Tao  
The most skilled  
soldier is not  
aggressive.  
The most proficient  
fighter never loses  
control.  
The most victorious  
commander does not  
bicker.  
The

The most skillful  
warriors are not  
warlike; the best  
fighters are not  
wrathful; the  
mightiest conquerors  
never strive; the  
greatest masters are

The best soldier is  
not soldierly;  
The best fighter is  
not ferocious;  
The best conqueror  
does not take part in  
war;  
The best employer of  
men keeps

Coinciding with  
Nature  
Those who are good  
champions don't  
battle.  
Those who are good  
at war don't get  
angry.  
Those who are good  
at defeating the  
enemy don't engage  
them.  
Those who are good  
at

the inner war, a spirit of  
vengeance inflames  
and empowers the  
demons of ego, since it  
casts us headlong into  
the bloody hell of  
opposition.  
This undermines the  
goal of  
self-development,  
which is to kill and  
transform the demonic  
consciousness of  
acculturation. To  
manage such a war  
correctly requires an  
attitude of  
humility—you put the  
work into the hands of  
those best able to do it  
right—the helping  
energies of the hidden  
world. This is how true  
greatness is achieved.

most efficient leader  
is humble before all.  
This is the virtue of  
serenity.  
This is the mastery of  
life.  
This is matching Teh  
to Tao.

ever lowly.  
This is the glory of  
non-strife; and the  
might of utilization;  
these equal heaven,  
they were the goal of  
the ancients

himself below them.  
This is called the  
virtue of not  
contending;  
This is the ability of  
using men;  
This is called the  
supremacy of  
consorting with  
heaven.

using people deem it  
as a something  
beneath them.  
This is called  
virtuosity at not  
contending.  
This is called the  
power of using  
people.  
This is called on a  
par with nature--the  
apex of antiquity.

The generals have a saying  
Which they apply to war,  
And I teach it too:  
Better to be aggression's  
guest,  
Than its partisan host.  
Better to draw back a mile  
Than press forward an inch.  
This is called marching  
Without moving your feet;  
Capturing without an assault;  
Defeating without an enemy.  
For there is no greater error  
Than looking outward for  
enemies.  
To look outward for enemies  
Is to estrange your only true  
self.  
This is why two sides  
opposed  
Will fight to a bloody draw,

**Tao Strategy**  
Ancient military  
strategists said:  
I would rather be  
invaded than be the  
invader.  
I would rather retreat  
one foot than  
advance one inch.  
This means not  
marching in  
formation;  
not appearing  
prepared, with  
sleeves up;  
not charging in  
frontal

Military commanders  
have a saying:  
I dare not act as host  
but only as a guest;  
rather than advance  
an inch I would retire  
a foot.  
This marching  
without moving;  
bearing the invisible  
arm; regarding the  
enemy as if he were  
not; grasping

An ancient tactician  
has said:  
'I dare not act as a  
host, but would  
rather act as a guest;  
I dare not advance an  
inch, but would  
rather retreat a foot.'  
This implies that he  
does not marshal the  
ranks as if there were  
no ranks;  
He does not roll up  
his sleeves as if he  
had

**Profound Use**  
There are slogans for  
using armies.  
"I don't presume to  
deem-act as lord and  
deem-act as guest.  
Don't presume to  
advance an inch and  
withdraw a foot."  
This is called  
"carrying out not  
carrying out.

This poem contains a  
warning against adopting a  
way of impulsive action,  
which will inevitably trap a  
person within a  
self-perpetuating cycle of  
opposition, where conflict is  
unceasing, battle lines always  
drawn and redrawn, where  
truce is tenuous and  
temporary, and where only  
sorrow wins. As elsewhere in  
the Tao Te Ching, the  
metaphor of "moving the  
feet" is symbolic of  
impulsive action—see also  
Chapters 31 and 64. Again,  
Lao Tzu points out that  
aggression tends to  
perpetuate itself: the search  
for outer enemies is the first  
and final act of  
self-destruction.

assault;  
not arming with  
elaborate weapons.  
There is no worse  
catastrophe  
than to underestimate  
the enemy.  
To underestimate the  
enemy  
is to run the risk of  
losing everything.  
When evenly  
matched armies do  
battle,  
the passive, recessive  
one is the victor.

the sword that is not.  
There is no calamity  
greater than making  
light of the enemy; to  
make light of the  
enemy is to endanger  
my retention of the  
treasures. Hence  
once the opposing  
forces have met it is  
the pitiful who  
conquer.

no arms;  
He does not seize as  
if he had no  
weapons;  
He does not fight as  
if there were no  
enemies.  
No calamity is  
greater than  
under-estimating the  
enemy.  
To under-estimate  
the enemy is to be on  
the point of losing  
our treasure (love).  
Therefore when  
opposing armies  
meet in the field the  
ruthful will win.

Bearing non-existent  
arms;  
Throwing against  
non-existent  
enemies.  
Controlling  
non-existing armies."  
No disaster is greater  
than taking an enemy  
lightly.  
Taking an enemy  
lightly almost brings  
my treasures to grief.  
Inherently, opposing  
armies strengthen  
each other.  
Grieving then wins.

Difficulty in  
Knowing How

My words are  
profoundly easy to  
know.

Profoundly easy to  
perform.

In the social world  
none are able to  
know or to perform.

Language has an  
ancestor and social

affairs have a ruler.

In general only lacking know-how--this counts as my know-how.

If those who know me are rare then things of mine are valuable.

Using this: Sages wrap precious jade in burlap.

|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |                                                                                                                                                              |                                                                                                                                                                             |                                                                                                                                                    |                                                                                                                                                         |
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| <p>Awareness of the poverty of knowledge</p> <p>Is all the knowledge you need.</p> <p>Repression of the awareness</p> <p>Is the seed of disease.</p> <p>You can remove the disease</p> <p>By watching the symptoms,</p> <p>And sickening their origin.</p> <p>Thus the follower of the Sage:</p> <p>He guards his health</p> <p>By being aware of disease.</p> <p>Thus he never seems sickened,</p> <p>Since he feels his own pain.</p> <p>Negative emotions, such as hatred, envy, pity, and contempt are the symptoms of the metaphorical disease described in this poem.</p>                                                                                                                                                                         | <p>On Intelligence</p> <p>To know what you do not know, is best.</p> <p>He who thinks he knows what he does not know,</p> <p>is sick in mind.</p> <p>One</p> | <p>The highest attainment is to know non-knowledge. To regard ignorance as knowledge is a disease. Only be feeling the pain of this disease do we cease to be diseased.</p> | <p>Not knowing that one knows is best;</p> <p>Thinking that one knows when one does not know is sickness.</p> <p>Only when one becomes sick of</p> | <p>Know-how as a disease</p> <p>Knowing not to know is better.</p> <p>Not knowing to know is a defect.</p> <p>In general, in only 'defecting'</p>       |
| <p>The symptoms of the disease must be watched, because they lead one to the "seed of disease," which is the arrogance of knowledge, exemplified in the false and superficial ideas that comprise the one-sided vision of scholarly accumulation (see also Chapter 81). True awareness is the consciousness of the poverty of knowledge in isolation from the totality of being; to fully sense this poverty is to "feel one's own pain," without the empty and officious compassion of a politician, a guru, or some other authority. This is the "awareness of disease" that Lao Tzu reminds us to nurture within ourselves: the deep self-knowledge that comes when you are acutely aware of not-knowing. This is the path of true independence.</p> | <p>who sees this sickness for what it is,</p> <p>is not sick in mind.</p> <p>The followers of Tao are not sick in mind, because they know this.</p>          | <p>The perfected man, because he knows the pain of it, is free from this disease. It is for this reason that he does not have it.</p>                                       | <p>the sickness can one be free from sickness.</p> <p>The sage is never sick; because he is sick of this sickness, therefore he is not sick.</p>   | <p>defects, using this is not to 'defect.'</p> <p>Sages do not 'defect' because they 'defect' defects.</p> <p>For this reason they do not 'defect.'</p> |

Let the fear of God die among the people,  
And they will find their own true guide within.  
Do not constrict them in their homes,  
Or oppress them at their work,  
For if the people lack a sense of burden,  
Then they will not feel oppressed.  
Thus, the teaching heart of the Cosmos:  
It is a living, dynamic consciousness-  
It draws close to sincerity,  
And retreats from exaltation.  
The former it receives,  
The latter it discards.

Lead Humbly But Surely  
When the people do not fear absolute rule,  
a greater fear will yet descend on them.  
Do not give them cramped quarters.  
Do not make sacrifice of their children.  
If you do not

The limits of the greatest fear have been reached when the people cease to fear that which is to be feared.  
Neither regard your lot as mean, nor despise the conditions of your birth, for that which

If the people have no fear of their ruling authority, still greater fear will come.  
Be sure not to give them too narrow

Self-love  
If the people do not fear authority then great authority has arrived.  
Don't toy around with things they are at home with.  
Don't despise things that contribute to their livelihood.  
In general, only if you don't

fear of God is of a distant and threatening Being, which can only inflict pain and guilt, while repressing one's inner truth (the "true Guide" mentioned).  
Societies and governments behave like such a daunting God-force when they dictate and limit the acceptable norms of living and working, even to the point of defining what a proper home and job must be. When these strictures are lifted, then there is the deepest liberation. Just be sincere, and you will be helped.

dislike them  
you will not be disliked yourself.  
The truly wise know themselves  
but do not flaunt themselves.  
The truly wise love themselves  
but do not take pride in themselves.  
They reject the one and accept the other.

is not despised  
arouses no disgust.  
Hence although the Holy Man knows himself he makes no display; although he loves himself he seeks no reputation.  
On this account he rejects the one while clinging to the other.

a dwelling;  
Nor make their living scanty.  
Only when their dwelling place is no longer narrow will their dissatisfaction come to an end.

despise [them], using this [they] will not despise [you].  
Using this: Sages start from what they know to do not from what they see.  
Start from love not from value.  
So they choose this and reject that.



|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <p>The wooden impetuosity of the hero</p> <p>Is the path of inner death.</p> <p>Courage that retreats from daring</p> <p>Is the path of inner life.</p> <p>Yet one who walks on either road</p> <p>Will sometimes suffer, sometimes prosper-</p> <p>As if God indeed played dice,</p> <p>While humans fought to find His Reason.</p> <p>The Cosmic Consciousness does not compete,</p>               | <p>One of courage, with audacity, will kill.</p> <p>One of courage, but gentle, spares life.</p> <p>From these two kinds of courage</p> <p>arise harm and benefit.</p> <p>Even if Tao dislikes certain people,</p> <p>who can say why?</p> <p>The truly wise regard this</p> <p>as a most difficult question.</p> | <p>The recklessly rash die. The cautiously courageous live. Of these two courses it is uncertain which is advantageous and which is disadvantageous, for who can explain why heaven disapproves? Therefore even the Holy Man feels a difficulty here.</p>                                                | <p>He who shows courage in daring will perish;</p> <p>He who shows courage in not-daring will live.</p> <p>To know these two is to distinguish the one, benefit, from the other, harm.</p> <p>Who can tell that one of them should be loathed by Heaven?</p> <p>The Tao of</p> | <p>Employing Deeming</p> <p>If one is courageously presumptuous, then--killing.</p> <p>If one is courageously non-presumptuous, then--living.</p> <p>These pairings : one benefits, one harms.</p> <p>That which nature despises, who knows its cause?</p> <p>Using this, sages make it even more difficult.</p> <p>The natural guide does not</p> |
| <p>simply finds its way.</p> <p>It doesn't have to talk or make its point,</p> <p>And thus it can communicate.</p> <p>It does not send an invitation,</p> <p>It so naturally attracts all being.</p> <p>It does not micromanage,</p> <p>And all its parts harmonize.</p> <p>The Cosmic Whole is like a net-</p> <p>So perfectly cast, its open meshes are capable</p> <p>Of catching everything.</p> | <p>Tao does not contend but it surely wins,</p> <p>does not speak but it surely responds,</p> <p>does not command but things come of themselves.</p> <p>It is empty yet contains the master plan.</p> <p>The net of Tao is all-encompassing,</p> <p>its meshes are wide, yet nothing is lost.</p>                 | <p>This is the way of heaven:</p> <p>Goodwill, which surely overcomes.</p> <p>Silence, which certainly responds.</p> <p>Without being summoned, spontaneously arriving.</p> <p>Acting leisurely, but planning effectively.</p> <p>Heaven's net spreads everywhere, wide in mesh, yet losing nothing.</p> | <p>heaven does not contend yet it surely wins the victory.</p> <p>It does not speak; yet it surely responds.</p> <p>It does not call; yet all things come of their own accord.</p> <p>The net of heaven is vast, and its meshes are wide; yet from it, nothing escapes.</p>    | <p>contend and yet is good at winning.</p> <p>Does not discourse and yet skillfully responds.</p> <p>Does not call and yet comes of itself.</p> <p>Insensate and yet good at planning.</p> <p>The natural net is all encompassing.</p> <p>It is loose and yet nothing is lost.</p>                                                                 |

People don't truly  
fear death,  
But they do fear  
being threatened with  
it.  
When people's fears  
are thus enlivened,  
It is a crime of  
intimidation-inner  
murder.  
But it is the criminal  
thought, and not the  
man,  
Who must be caught  
and killed.  
There may always be  
those who use death

Capital Punishment  
If the people do not  
fear death,  
why threaten them  
with it?  
If the people do fear  
death,  
and if the unlawful  
be killed,  
who would dare to  
execute

Why use death as a  
deterrent, when the  
people have no fear  
of death?  
Even supposing they  
shrank from death as  
from a monster, and  
by playing on their  
terror I could slay  
them, should I

When the people are  
not afraid of death,  
what use is it to  
frighten them with  
the punishment of  
death? If the people  
were constantly  
afraid of death and  
we could arrest and  
kill those who  
commit treacheries,  
who then would  
commit such?

Controlling Feelings  
When the people are  
not afraid off death  
For what reason  
would you use death  
to frighten them?  
If you cause the  
people to constant  
fear of death  
And yet those who  
deem: act deviantly,  
we take, hold and kill  
them,  
who

to further power,  
But they are not to be  
opposed.  
For they would usurp  
the place of the  
Cosmic Artisan,  
And try to do the  
work of Nature  
Without the ability to  
use its tools.  
Thus, the pretenders  
will but seldom fail  
To shed the blood of  
their own  
incompetence.

them?  
Only the Supreme  
Executioner kills.  
To take His place is  
to set an unskilled  
man  
to wield the hatchet  
of the master  
carpenter:  
he rarely escapes  
chopping off his own  
hand!

dare?  
There is one who  
inflicts sentence of  
death. To usurp his  
functions and to kill  
would be to assume  
the role of  
Master-Carpenter.  
There are few who  
can act as  
Master-Carpenter  
without cutting their  
hands.

Only the Supreme  
Executioner kills. To  
kill in place of the  
Supreme Executioner  
is to hack instead of a  
great carpenter. Now  
if one hacks in place  
of a great carpenter  
one can scarcely  
avoid cutting one's  
own hand.

will dare do it?  
Should we constant  
having a professional  
executor do the  
killing?  
To delegate a  
professional executor  
for killing,  
Is this called  
"delegating the great  
carpenter to chop"?  
Those who delegate  
the great carpenter to  
chop are few.  
It doesn't hurt his  
hand.

People go hungry because taxes eat their food.

Therefore, the people go hungry.

People are hard to manage because they are oppressed.

Therefore, they are hard to manage.

People laugh at death because their lives are cheapened

With the weight of expectation.

This is why they laugh at death.

Who could value life

When food is scarce, and freedom repressed?

The peculiar structure of this verse, with its apparently clumsy redundancy, has been a matter of comment and rationalization by scholars and translators.

**Rule Without Interfering**

The people starve when rulers impose heavy taxes.

That is why people starve.

The people are rebellious when rulers meddle in their affairs.

That is why people are rebellious.

The

The people suffer from famine because of the multitude of taxes consumed by their superiors. Because of this they suffer from famine. The people are difficult to govern because of the officiousness of their superiors; because of this they are difficult to govern.

The people starve. Because their officials take heavy taxes from them, therefore they starve. The people are hard to rule.

**The Destructiveness of Envy**

Starvation among the people comes from how much taxes-in-kind those above them 'eat'.

From this: they starve.

The difficulty in governing people comes from those above them taking deeming-action.

From this: they

Perhaps this poem's structure is best explained as a matter of emphasis: Lao Tzu is underscoring the inexorable and appalling connection between taxation and hunger, oppression and rebellion, despair and the cheapening of life. The expression "the people" is not a mere empty ideological abstraction, to be written into constitutions and political speeches, while each unique individual within the nation is forgotten or suppressed. Lao Tzu uses the alliterative language of verse to make a subtle but crucial point: "the people" are real beings, not a collective abstraction, and so when a government represses their natural freedom or robs them of their livelihood, then it has stolen from the treasure of each individual's life and its potential.

people do not fear death

when they try to lead a better life.

That is why they do not fear death.

Those who do not interfere with life receive genuine value from it.

Men are continually dying because they lust after life; because of this they frequently die.

It is only those with whom life is no object who truly value life.

Because their officials meddle with affairs, therefore they are hard to rule. The people pay no heed to death. Because they endeavour to seek life; therefore they pay no heed to death.

are difficult to govern.

People take death lightly because those above them seek life's richness.

From this they take death lightly.

In general: only those who don't deem-act using 'life' --these are worthies at valuing life.

When we are born,  
We are soft and tender.  
After we die,  
We become rigid and brittle.  
A living tree can sway,  
A living blade of grass can bend,  
For suppleness is the strength of life.  
Only in death is flexibility stilled.  
Tough and taut is the

Living, man is supple and yielding;  
when dead, man is hard and stiff.  
Living, animals and plants are soft and pliant;  
when dead, they are withered and brittle.  
Being inflexible and unyielding is part of dying;  
being

At birth man is supple and weak, at death rigid and strong. So with inanimate nature – say the vegetable creation – in its early growth it is pliable and brittle, at death it is decayed and withered.

Man when living is soft and tender; when dead he is hard and tough. All animals and plants when living are tender and fragile; when dead they become withered and dry. Therefore it is said: the hard and the tough are parts of death, the soft and the tender are parts of life.

Strength's Warning Signs.  
The human living state is soft and pliable.  
The dead state is hard and rigid.  
The alive state of the ten-thousand natural kinds --grass and wood--is soft and crisp.  
Their dead state is hard and dry.  
So things that are hard

body of death;  
Gently moving is the way of life.  
Powerful forces crush themselves  
Because they cannot move or yield.  
A stiff and heavy tree will soon be broken  
By wind or by axe.  
Thus does rigid power always crumble,  
While the supple and the humble  
Gently endure.

flexible and yielding is part of living.  
A headstrong legion will lose in war just as an unyielding tree will snap under the axe.  
The place of the strong is below;  
the place of the gentle is above.

It follows that rigidity and strength are the way to death; pliability and gentleness the way to life.  
Hence a soldier who is arrogant cannot conquer; the tree which is strong is doomed.  
The firm and the great occupy the lower place, the pliable and the meek the higher.

This is the reason why soldiers when they are too tough cannot carry the day; the tree when it is too tough will break. The Position of the strong and great is low, and the position of the weak and tender is high.

and rigid accompany death.  
Things that are soft and pliable accompany life.  
So if troops are strong they do not triumph.  
When wood is stiff, it makes weapons.  
When strength is great, its place is down.  
When soft and pliable, its place is up.

## Chapter 77

The Tao of life is like the drawing of a bow,  
Yet without the arrow:  
Higher and lower are mutually attracted,  
Until they seem to change places.  
The long and the short complement  
And support the function of the whole.  
The Tao of life draws off excess,  
And provides for what is depleted.  
The way of man departs from this:  
It devours the dwindling resources  
To serve contrived, compulsive needs.  
How can we learn to use the gifts of Nature,  
Amid this grasping world?  
Let the Tao guide you:

Is not Tao like the drawn bow?  
The highest part is lowered,  
the lowest part is raised.  
Overall length is shortened,  
overall depth is lengthened.  
So the Great Tao  
lowers the highest  
and raises the lowest.  
But the Tao of man  
increases the

The Divine Way is like the drawing of a bow, it brings down the high and exalts the low. Where there is superfluity it takes away, where there is deficiency it imparts. It is the way of heaven to diminish abundance, and supplement deficiency.

The way of man is not so.

Is not the Tao of heaven like the drawing of a bow? It brings down the part which is high; it raises the part which is low; it lessens the part which is redundant (convex); it fills up the part which is insufficient (concave). The Tao of heaven is to lessen the redundant and fill up the insufficient. The Tao of man, on the contrary, is to take from the insufficient and give to the redundant.

The Natural Guide

The guide of nature:  
Is it not like a taut  
bow?

That which is high,  
represses them.

That which is low,  
raise them up.

That which has  
abundance, pare it  
back.

That which is  
insufficient, add to it.

The guide of nature  
is to pare back  
abundance and add to  
the insufficient.

If it's the guide of  
humans then it's not

high and decreases  
the low.

Who can take from  
the high and give to  
the low?

Only the true  
follower of Tao.

Thus, the truly wise  
act but are not  
possessive,  
achieve but claim no  
credit,  
because they have no  
desire for vain glory.

He depletes the deficient, that he may supplement the superfluous.

Who is able to have a superabundance for the service of the world? Only the possessor of the Tao! Hence the Holy Man acts without priding himself on his actions, completes his work without lingering on it; he has no desire to display his superiority.

Who can take from the redundant and give to the insufficient? Only he who has Tao can. Therefore the Sage does not horde. The more he helps others, the more he benefits himself the more he gives to others, the more he gets himself. The Tao of heaven does one good but never does one harm; the Tao of the Sage acts but never contends.

like that.

It injures that which is not sufficient and piles it on that which has abundance.

Who can have abundance and use it to pile it on the social world?

Only one who has a guide.

Using this: Sages Deem-act and don't rely on anything.

His work is accomplished and he doesn't locate it.

This is his not desiring the apprehending of worthies.

|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |                                                                                                                                                                                                          |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
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| <p>Is there anything in all of Nature</p> <p>As adaptable and as shapeless as water?</p> <p>But for wearing down what's fixed and rigid,</p> <p>No power on earth can match it.</p> <p>Thus, it is unique.</p> <p>When an amorphous presence</p> <p>Meets adamant resistance,</p> <p>The amorphous prevails.</p> <p>When the supple meets the obdurate,</p> <p>Suppleness prevails.</p> | <p>Nothing in the world is weaker</p> <p>or more yielding than water.</p> <p>Yet nothing is its equal</p> <p>in wearing away the hard and strong.</p> <p>There is nothing quite like it.</p> <p>Thus the weak can overpower the strong;</p> <p>the flexible can overcome the rigid.</p> <p>The whole world can perceive</p> | <p>Nothing is so flexible as water, yet for attacking that which is hard nothing surpasses it. There is nothing which supplants it.</p> <p>The weak overcomes the strong, the soft control the hard.</p> | <p>The weakest things in the world can overmatch the strongest things in the world.</p> <p>Nothing in the world can be compared to water for its weak and yielding nature; yet in attacking the hard and the strong, nothing proves better than it. For there is no other alternative to it.</p> <p>The weak can overcome the strong and</p> | <p>Recognizing Fidelity</p> <p>In the social world, nothing is softer or more pliant than water.</p> <p>And yet when it attacks firm, rigid things, none of them is able to win.</p> <p>This is due to their lacking that with which to metamorphose it.</p> <p>That the pliant wins over the rigid, the soft wins over the hard,</p> |
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| <p>There are none who can deny this,</p> <p>But no one seems able to live by it.</p> <p>Thus the Sage teaches that</p> <p>The humiliation of one's country</p> <p>Is not to be taken upon one's self,</p> <p>Nor are environmental disasters</p> <p>To be conquered as enemies.</p> <p>But we can, with subtle understanding,</p> <p>Communicate with them.</p> | <p>this,</p> <p>but does not put it into practice.</p> <p>And so the truly wise say:</p> <p>Whoever bears the shame of the nation</p> <p>is fit to lead the nation.</p> <p>Whoever bears the sins of the world</p> <p>is fit to lead the world.</p> <p>Straight words (truth) can seem crooked (paradoxical).</p> | <p>Everyone knows this, but no one practices it.</p> <p>Hence a Sage has said – "Who bears his country's reproach is hailed as the lord of his nation's altars. Who bears his country's misfortunes is called the Empire's chief."</p> <p>Truth, when expressed in speech, appears paradoxical.</p> | <p>the yielding can overcome the hard: This all the world knows but does not practise.</p> <p>Therefore the Sage says:</p> <p>He who sustains all the reproaches of the country can be master of the land;</p> <p>He who sustains all the calamities of the country can be king of the world.</p> <p>These are words of truth,</p> <p>Though they seem paradoxical.</p> | <p>In the social world, no one fails to know.</p> <p>[Yet] no one is able to execute.</p> <p>Using this: Sages say, "Taking the soil of a state, this is called ruler of the world's grain alters.</p> <p>Taking the non-auspicious state, this is being deemed the king of the social world."</p> <p>Rectified language is like its opposite.</p> |
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| <p>A great conflict, even when resolved,<br/>Leaves behind a bitter taste.</p> <p>How can the residue of enmity be cleansed?</p> <p>The teaching of the Sage is this:</p> <p>Hold not to your claim, but to</p> | <p>Settling Disputes</p> <p>Settling a great dispute leaves some hatred behind.</p> <p>Can this be good?</p> <p>Therefore the truly wise defend the weak and do not seek vengeance.</p> | <p>To compromise a great hate leaves ill-will behind; that is only a bleeding which produces tranquility.</p> <p>Therefore the Holy Man does not pry into other people's affairs, even when he holds the left-hand bond, possessing the attributes of</p> | <p>Return love for great hatred.</p> <p>Otherwise, when a great hatred is reconciled, some of it will surely remain.</p> <p>How can this end in goodness?</p> <p>Therefore the Sage holds to the left half of an</p> | <p>Recognizing Agreements</p> <p>Settling a massive resentment</p> <p>Necessarily some resentment will be left-over.</p> <p>How can such be deemed as worth?</p> <p>Using this: Sages grasp the left side of the</p> |
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| <p>your contract.</p> <p>Abandon entitlement and accept obligation.</p> <p>Trust in the virtues of the Cosmic Way:</p> <p>Disperse guilt and depart from blame.</p> <p>The Tao plays no favorites,</p> <p>But calls upon the inner truth of all.</p> | <p>The man with Teh fosters reconciliation; the man without Teh fosters reaction.</p> <p>And so it is truly said:</p> <p>While Tao is impartial, it permeates good men.</p> | <p>the Tao, he quietly holds his own; he who lacks the qualities of Tao strives to put everybody right.</p> <p>It is heaven's way to be without favourites, and to be always on the side of the good man.</p> | <p>agreement, but does not exact what the other holder ought to do.</p> <p>The virtuous resort to agreement.</p> <p>The virtueless resort to exaction.</p> <p>The Tao of heaven shows no partiality;</p> <p>It abides always with good men.</p> | <p>agreement.</p> <p>And don't demand from others.</p> <p>Have virtuosity in supervising agreements.</p> <p>Lack virtuosity in supervising taxation.</p> <p>The natural guide has no kin.</p> <p>It constants being with worthy people.</p> |
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## Chapter 81

Words that resonate  
may not be eloquent,  
But eloquence may  
never resonate.

Pure being does not  
argue;  
Those who argue  
pervert pure being.

Understanding is not  
scholarly;  
A scholar's way lacks  
understanding.

The Sage does not  
hoard its teaching:  
The more it gives us,  
The

Words of truth are  
not high-sounding;  
high-sounding words  
are not the truth.

One who has Teh  
does not argue;  
one who argues does  
not have Teh.

The truly wise do not  
know many things;  
one who knows  
many things is not  
truly wise.

Sincere words are not (necessarily) pleasant, nor are pleasant words (necessarily) sincere.

The good are not (necessarily) skillful debaters, not are skillful debaters (necessarily) good men.

The wise are not (necessarily) well informed, nor are the well informed (necessarily) wise.

The Holy Man does not accumulate.

He who knows does  
not speak;  
He who speaks does  
not know.  
He who is truthful is  
not showy;  
He who is showy is  
not truthful.  
He who is virtuous  
does not

Making the Essence Clear

Accurate language is not beautiful.

Beautiful language is not accurate.

Those who are good at [things] don't distinguish.

Those who distinguish are not good at [things].

Those who know-how are not comprehensive.

Those who are comprehensive do not know how.

Sages don't accumulate.

Although they use it to deem-act "others"

Themselves increase 'having'

Although they use it to give others.

Themselves increase in magnitude.

The guide of nature: benefit and yet do not harm.

more it is fulfilled.

For giving is the way  
of true increase.

The way of Tao is  
benevolent:

It does not harm or  
punish.

The Tao brings all  
things to completion,

In the endless dance  
of its Harmony.

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The truly wise do not selfishly crave.  
They live for other people  
and thereby grow richer.  
They give freely of themselves  
and thereby have great abundance.  
The great Tao endows,  
but does so unconditionally.  
The Tao of the wise accomplishes,  
but does so unselfishly.

He works for others,  
yet ever has  
abundance for  
himself; he gives to  
others, yet himself  
ever possesses  
superabundance.

The divine way is  
advantageous,  
without danger; the  
way of the Sages is  
effective without  
struggle.

[ ]

dispute.

He who disputes is not virtuous.

He who is learned is not wise.

He who is wise is not learned.

Therefore the Sage does not display his own merits.

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